

Designing for the Indian Context

Tools for reading products, pictures, language and people's material lives, before you design for them.



1 · EXISTING PRODUCTS

2 · VISUAL CULTURE

3 · LANGUAGE

4 · MATERIAL REALITY

REFLECTION COMING

Every product assumes a world.

A personal phone. Steady data. A scanner nearby. In India that world isn't the same for everyone. When it doesn't match, people build their own way around — or give up. This toolkit helps you see that gap before you design.

WITHOUT IT

“Improve the upload experience.”

WITH IT

“The upload assumes a scanner that isn't there. It costs her a cybercafé trip and a relay through her father. It's not an interface problem.”

MADE FOR

Design students

Product teams

NGO & public-service teams

Field researchers

Four ways of reading, in this edition.

Each component reads a design problem from a different side. Each works on its own. Used together, they give you a fuller picture of the person you're designing for.

1

Reading Existing Products

Whose user is built into a product, and who pays when it's wrong about them.

MEDIA & GOSSIP

HISTORY

THE BREAK

POWER

STARTS P.1.01 · 3-4 H · CARD KIT
P.1.11

2

Reading Visual Culture

What people have learned to notice, trust and act on, shown through their own photos.

SHOW

READ

BUILD

HAND OFF

STARTS P.2.01 · ABOUT A WEEK

3

Reading Language

What people mean, not just what they say, tested before it reaches a screen.

LISTEN

TRANSLATE

TEST

LIBRARY

KAHAVAT RELAY

STARTS P.3.01 · SEVERAL SESSIONS

4

Reading Material Reality

What people actually have around them, what it costs them, and who they lean on.

BUILD

BREAK

WEIGH

SAY

STARTS P.4.01 · 2-4 H

RUNS THROUGH EVERY COMPONENT

Claim & Reflection

A Before page at the start of each component, a Claim page at the end, and three Look back pages in Closing.

STARTS P.07 · R PAGES

Just one.

Be specific. One real person, one real thing.

One real product, or one action someone had to do. Follow it from start to end, the way it actually happened. Every component in this book works on something you can point to.

WHAT COUNTS AS “ONE REAL THING”

A named product you can open, or an action with a clear start and end. It can happen on a phone, on paper, or in person.

GOOD

- ✓ Meera uploading her documents for a scholarship
- ✓ A shopkeeper paying the electricity bill
- ✓ The National Scholarship Portal

TOO BROAD

- ✗ Students using government portals
- ✗ How rural users pay bills
- ✗ Government portals

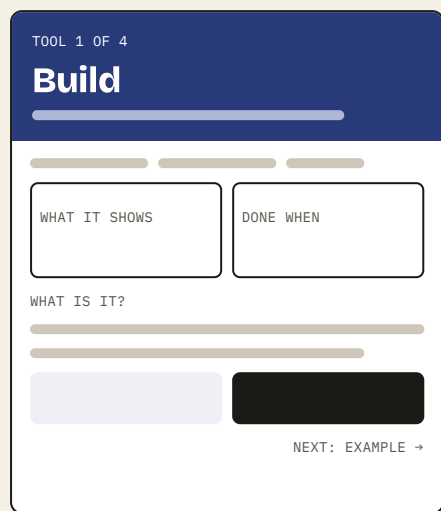
Everything else is yours to adapt: which components and tools you use, their order, the labels, the language.

How to read this toolkit

- 1 Pick a component (p.03).**
Each one works on its own. Read its opening pages first.
- 2 Pick a tool. Read its page: what it shows you, and when you're done.**
- 3 Turn the page: follow the steps on the example.**
- 4 Turn again: print the blank template and fill it for your person.**
- 5 Take what you made to the next tool, or stop there.**

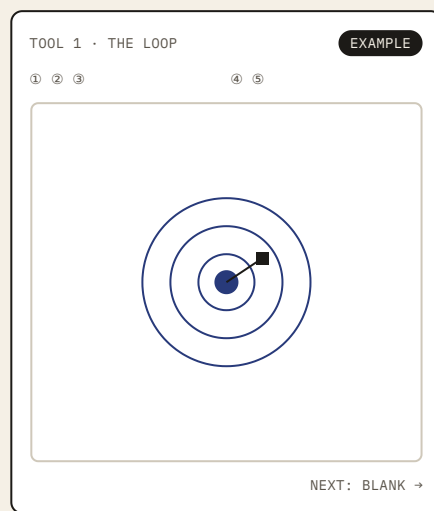
This is how every tool's pages look

Three pages, always in this order.



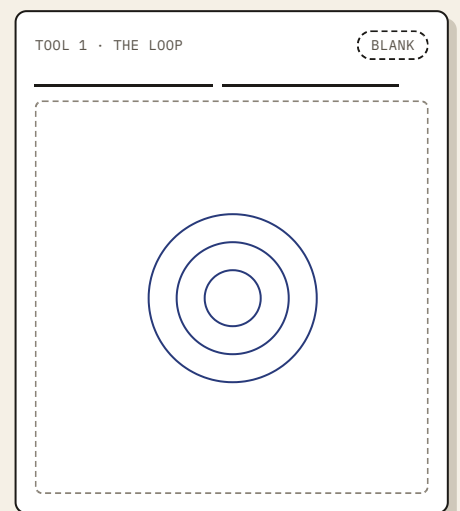
1 • The tool page

What you'll get and why



2 • The example

How to use it, shown with Meera



3 • The blank template

Print it and fill it in



Meet Meera.

Our example persona. She appears in every component.

WHO

First in her family at college

WHERE

Hostel in a Tier-2 town; family in a village

DEVICE

Her own Android phone, prepaid data

TASK

Upload documents to a national scholarship portal

THE SCREEN

“PDF only, max 200KB.”

Plus an OTP to the registered number. If it fails: an error, with no hint how to fix it.

It takes her **three days**, a cybercafé, her father's phone and a family trip home. One attempt is lost when her data runs out.

Now use your own persona.

Take the persona from your project. No persona yet? Make one before you start: who they are, where they live, what phone they use, and the one thing they had to do.

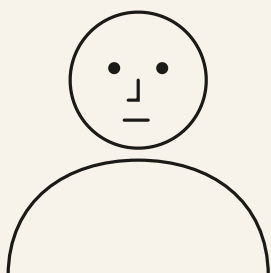
CLAIM & REFLECTION.

DFIC 07

CLAIM & REFLECTION

READ BEFORE COMPONENT 1 • RUNS THROUGH EVERY COMPONENT

I want to know what the process gave me that I did not already have.



What is it & why should I do it?

It starts **before** the work, not after it. You write down where you are positioned, what you expect to find, and what that expectation is built from.

After the component, you make a claim from what the process actually gave you. You test it against your own familiarity, name what is still unknown, and look at what your method may have missed.

The output is not a polished conclusion. It is a traceable account of what changed, what you can support, and what you still cannot.



HOW TO USE IT

Fill **Before Component N** before you open its first tool. Fill **After Component N** as soon as its last page is done. At the end of the toolkit, go back to your predictions with the three **Look back** pages.

METHOD FLOW

1 POSITION

Where are you speaking from?

2 PREDICTION

What do you expect, and why?

3 CLAIM

What did the process actually give you?

4 REDACTION

What survives your own bias check?

5 SUMMARISE

What changed, surprised, or stayed missing?

WHERE YOU'LL FIND THESE PAGES

STEPS 1-2

Before each component

C1	R · 1A • AFTER 1.02
C2	R · 2A • AFTER 2.02
C3	R · 3A • AFTER 3.03
C4	R · 4A • AFTER 4.03

STEPS 3-4

After each component

C1	R · 1B • AFTER 1.10
C2	R · 2B • AFTER 2.15
C3	R · 3B • AFTER 3.24
C4	R · 4B • AFTER 4.22

STEP 5 • IN CLOSING

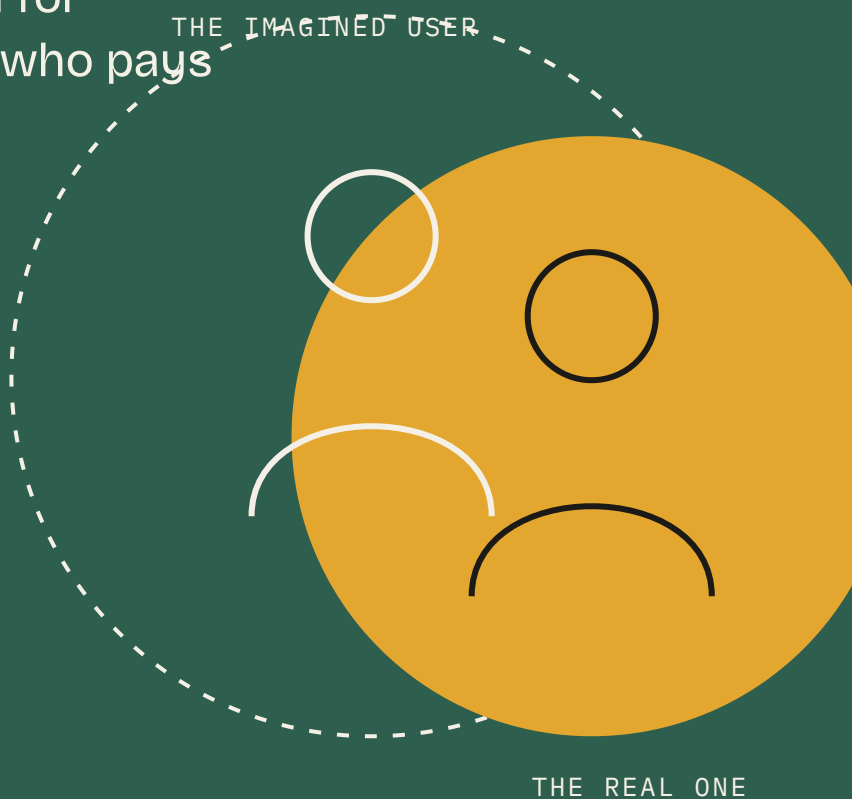
Look back

Summarise	R · E1
Wheel	R · E2
Consequences	R · E3

Only using one component? Do its Before and After pages, then go straight to the three Look back pages. They take about 30 minutes.

Reading Existing Products

Every product was designed for someone. Find out who, and who pays when it isn't them.



4 TOOLS + SYNTHESIS

3-4 HOURS

STICKY NOTES, 3 COLOURS

OPTIONAL CARD KIT

Every product was designed for someone. Find out who.

Then find out who pays when the product is wrong about them. This is not a usability audit.

STEP 0 · PICK ONE PRODUCT

The product we're reading is [National Scholarship Portal · or Google Maps, DigiLocker...]

One product you can open right now. Not a category: "Google Maps", not "navigation apps".

How every page works

Every page after this one is a template. Fill it straight away. Anything in *[brackets]* is an example, from Meera's scholarship portal. Write over it with your own.

At the bottom of each tool, write **one line to carry forward**. Synthesis uses those lines, so you never have to reread.

THE ROUTE · ABOUT 3 HOURS · EACH TOOL ALSO WORKS ON ITS OWN

1 Media & Gossip

45 min · p.1.03



2 History

20 min · p.1.05



3 The Break

45 min · p.1.06



4 Power

30 min · p.1.08



Synthesis

20 min · p.1.09

YOU NEED

The product open on a phone or laptop. Pens. Sticky notes, if you like. The colours are explained on the page where you first use them.

WORKING AS A TEAM?

There's a card kit with big boards and printed cards (p.1.11). The green S1 tags on templates show which card goes where.

NEXT PAGE **Tool 1 · The Media Story** →

BEFORE COMPONENT 1

R·1A

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 1-2 · POSITION + PREDICTION · FILL BEFORE 1.03 MEDIA STORY

COMPONENT 1 · READING EXISTING PRODUCTS

Before I begin,
I want to make my starting position visible.

1 POSITION

Your device. Your language at home. Your city.

Device _____

Language at home _____

City _____

Have you used this product, avoided it, or never needed it?

☐

Used it

☐

Avoided it

☐

Never needed it

Because _____

What else might shape how you see this person or product?

2 PREDICTION

FOR THIS COMPONENT, PREDICT

whose user this product was built for, and where it lets your person down.

What do you expect to find?

Why do you expect to find that?

What do you think it could mean? What do you already know about this context that is making you predict this?

Keep this page visible while you work. Do not change the prediction until the component is complete.

WHEN THE COMPONENT IS DONE
AFTER COMPONENT 1 · R·1B

The Media Story

What the product promises, and who it imagines, compared with your real user. Spend 15 minutes with real ads, the app store page or official notices first.

Step 1 · Who does the product think it's for? Describe the person the ads show. Then describe the person who really uses it. The **gap between the two** is what this tool is looking for.

THE PERSON IN THE ADS

Who: [a smiling student]

Has: [own laptop, bright desk]

Doing it: [in one sitting, relaxed]

YOUR REAL USER

Who: [Meera, 19, first-gen]

Has: [a phone at 12%, hostel Wi-Fi]

Doing it: [over 3 days, worried]

THE MISMATCH

The ads assume [a laptop, a scanner and an hour], but my user has [a phone, a café and three days]

A · What it claims

Its main promise, in its own words

["one place for all scholarships"]

A word the ads keep using that the product doesn't live up to

["seamless"]

If a user described it to a friend, they'd say...

["upload karo, reject ho jao, phir se karo"]

B · The story it sells

Where the ads' story starts

[log-in]

Where it ends

["Submitted"]

What it skips

[getting documents, the café, the waiting]

C · What the designers set out to do

The problem they set out to solve, in their own words (launch page, tender, About)

["let students apply for every scholarship on one platform"]

The user they imagined

[own laptop, scanner, broadband]

What they designed against, and what it costs users

[fraud; heavy document checks for everyone]

D · How users experience it

First time (signing up)

[asked for an ID she didn't have with her]

Using it (the main task)

[upload rejected twice, no reason given]

Afterwards (waiting, coming back)

[status says "pending" for weeks]

yellow notes · what you found teal notes · what you think

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

The Gossip Venn

The three circles are three **sources of information** about the product. Collect real quotes from each, then look at where they agree and where they clash.

HOW TO FILL IT

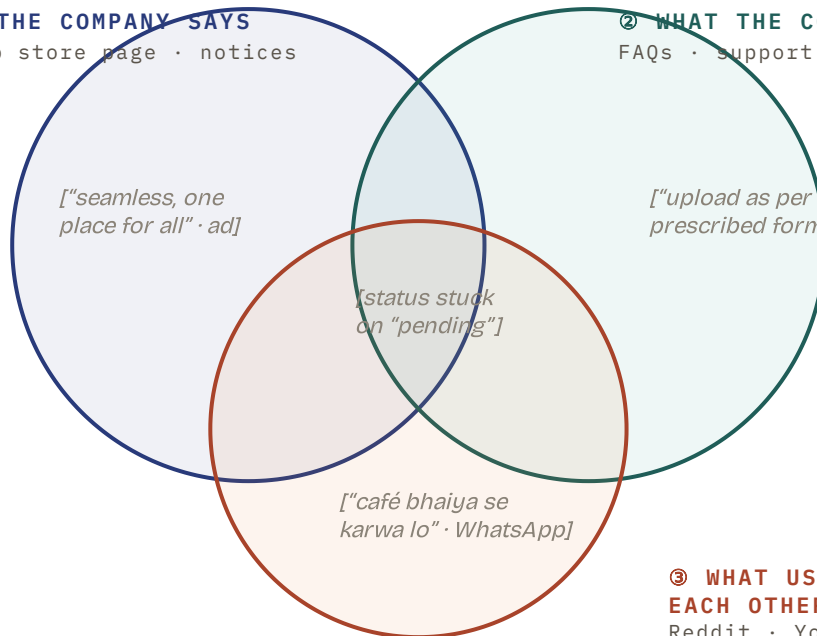
Write each quote on a yellow note, with where you found it. Stick it in the circle it came from. If two sources say the same thing, put it in the overlap. Never invent a quote.

① WHAT THE COMPANY SAYS

ads · app store page · notices

② WHAT THE COMPANY REPLIES

FAQs · support · replies to reviews



③ WHAT USERS TELL EACH OTHER

Reddit · YouTube · WhatsApp

THE HARDEST CONTRADICTION · teal notes · what you think

Circle ① says "[track your status anytime]", but circle ③ says "[nobody can tell you where your application is]".

Why hasn't it been fixed? Who gains from it staying this way?

[the helpdesk only answers FAQs; agents earn from the confusion]

WHERE TO FIND ③

Reddit

Quora

YouTube comments

WhatsApp forwards

Facebook groups

Your interviews

ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

The timeline

What the product replaced, who lost or gained a role, and which way influence flows. Best done by talking to someone who did it before it went digital.

Then	Recently	Now
<i>[paper form; principal signs; father takes it to the district office; a clerk checks it]</i>	<i>[apply online, then hand a printout to the college]</i>	<i>[fully online; OTP to a registered phone; college verifies]</i>
PEOPLE → PRODUCT A workaround users invented that the product now depends on <i>[the café "setting" for 200KB PDFs]</i>	PRODUCT → PEOPLE A habit or skill the product forced on everyone <i>[owning a PDF, an OTP number and an email]</i>	

Who lost a role?
[the clerk who could explain and make exceptions]

Who gained one?
[cybercafé owners, form-filling agents]

What did the product remove that people used to be able to do?
[plead your case to a person who could bend a rule]

Which power stayed the same, in a new form?
[the principal's signature became the college's online check]

Which direction of influence do you see more evidence for: people shaping the product, or the product shaping people?
[product → people: everyone had to change]

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY TO SYNTHESIS
[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

Ideal flow + what each step needs

Map the product's main feature the way the designers imagined it: everything works. Then write what each step quietly needs from the user.

The feature: [upload documents and submit] Its goal:

["application submitted, confirmation received"]

WRITE EACH STEP AS A SHORT VERB ON AN ORANGE NOTE. THEN FILL THE FOUR ROWS. · orange notes · the story

Steps as designed	1 [logs in with mobile]	2 [fills in details]	3 [uploads marksheet PDF]	4 [enters OTP]	5 [submits]	6 [gets confirmation]
People who must help?		[a parent, for income]	[café owner]	[father (his phone)]		
Objects what must they own?	[own phone number]	[Aadhaar]	[scanner, PDF]	[the registered phone]	[data pack]	[email]
Systems what else must work?	[SMS]	[Aadhaar match]	[upload]	[SMS on time]	[server]	[college checks]
Information what must they know?	[which number]	[exact spelling]	[under 200KB]	[OTP expires fast]	[midnight deadline]	[to chase the college]

Put a dot on every need the product leaves the user to sort out alone. Count them: ____ of ____

WHO WAS THIS DESIGNED FOR? · teal notes · what you think

This flow only works smoothly for someone who has

[their own laptop, a scanner, broadband and an uninterrupted hour]

ONE LINE TO CARRY FORWARD · THE STEP MOST LIKELY TO BREAK

[step 3, the upload: it needs a scanner and a PDF]

The Villain Story

Now imagine everything going wrong. Walk someone very unlike the ideal user through **your ideal flow from p.1.06**, one step at a time.

1 · YOUR VILLAIN PERSONA · orange notes · the story

My persona is [Meera, 19, applying on her phone], and their one hard constraint is [the registered phone is her father's]

2 · WALK THE FLOW

Step = a step number from your ideal flow on p.1.06. At each step, pick **one of the five failure cards** below: the one most likely to happen to this persona. Cut the cards out and lay one on each step, or just write its name.

STEP (FROM P.1.06)	FAILURE CARD	WHAT BROKE · WHAT THEY DID INSTEAD	HOW LIKELY	WHO PAYS, AND WHAT
[3]	[Object missing]	[no scanner, no PDF; pays a café]	[8/10]	[Meera: ₹30–50, half a day]
[4]	[Person unavailable]	[father in the field; OTP expires]	[7/10]	[a day; father's work]
			/10	
			/10	
			/10	

Star ★ the likeliest break.

3 · QUICK CHECK: WHO GETS BLAMED?

When step [3] fails, the error message makes it sound like the fault of ○ **the user** ○ **the product**. It should instead say ["Photos work too. We'll make the PDF for you."]

System failure

Something in your Systems row doesn't work.

Person unavailable

Someone from your People row isn't there.

Object missing

Something from your Objects row isn't at hand.

Information gap

They don't know it, and the product doesn't say.

No time

Everything is there, except the time it needs.

↳ ONE LINE TO CARRY FORWARD · THE LIKELIEST BREAK

[step 3: no way to make a PDF on a phone (8/10)]

Zoom out from one user to everyone around the product: who built it, what it protects, and whose work keeps it running. Look things up rather than guessing.

It was built by [a government IT agency, through a vendor] . They seem to have been ☐ rushing ☐ saving money ☐ ticking boxes, because [errors read "file size exceeds limit"]

The most effort is demanded at [document checks] . That protects [the scheme from fraud]
 , not [students from failing] . Reaching a real person takes [4+] steps.

After using it, people are more ○ independent ○ dependent, because [they need a café and a father's phone] . It asks them to hand over [income, bank and ID details]

[the café owner (paid by the student)] • [her father, who receives the OTP]
[college staff, now doing tech support]

[OTP goes to someone else's phone]

[errors are written for engineers]

[write it now, so you don't have to reread later]

Make the stories compete

Copy your five carried lines. Then fill the sentences in order. Every blank should point to something you already wrote.

1 · YOUR CARRIED LINES · COPY, DON'T REREAD

Media [promises "one place, seamless"]

Gossip [nobody can tell you where your application is]

History [you can no longer plead your case to a person]

The Break [no way to make a PDF on a phone (8/10)]

Power [it only works because of unpaid helpers]

2 · THE SHARPEST CONTRADICTION

The product claims [to be one seamless place], but [the Villain Story] revealed
[it needs a scanner, a café and a father's phone]

3 · THREE POSSIBLE REDESIGNS · SPECIFIC SCREENS OR STEPS

A [photo-to-PDF inside the upload step] B [an error that says how to fix it] C
[OTP to a number she chooses]

The one that takes the most blame off the user is [A], because
[she no longer needs a scanner or a café]

4 · THE POWER TEST

If this were built, [students without scanners] would gain [a free way to submit].
[Cafés and agents] would resist it, because [they'd lose paid work]

5 · THE FINDING

This product assumes [a scanner and a PDF], but the user actually has
[a phone camera], which causes [a paid trip, a lost day and self-blame]

6 · THE DESIGN CLAIM

We should redesign [the upload step], because it would shift blame from
[the student] to [the portal's missing PDF path], and would specifically help
[students who only have a phone]

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

- ✓ The hardest contradiction in the Venn surprises you.
- ✓ The dots on your ideal flow make you uneasy about assumptions you'd have made yourself.
- ✓ Your villain persona turns out to be common, not rare.
- ✓ Your five carried lines point at the same problem from different sides.
- ✓ You name people the product has never named.

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ All three Venn circles say the same thing.
Research deeper, or pick a product people actually talk about.
- ✗ Your villain is just the ideal user with one inconvenience.
Pick a harder constraint: a shared phone, a missing document, a passed deadline.
- ✗ "Specifically help ____" names a category, not a person.
Go back to Unpaid helpers (p.108) and name one person.
- ✗ You can fill the design claim without looking at your carried lines.
It's coming from your head, not the evidence. Go back to the table.

AFTER COMPONENT 1

R · 1B

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 3-4 • CLAIM + REDACTION • FILL RIGHT AFTER 1.10 IS IT WORKING?

COMPONENT 1 • READING EXISTING PRODUCTS

What did the process actually give me?
Not what I set out to find.

1 THE STANZA

Write one paragraph, not a list, about what you actually learned. Not what you set out to find. What the process gave you that you did not already have when you started.

[illegible]

2 REDACTION

Read your stanza back slowly. **Underline** anything that might come from your own familiarity, frustration or background rather than the evidence. What is left un-underlined is the part you can stand behind.

What's left that I can stand behind:

3 STILL UNKNOWN

Name one specific thing you went looking for and couldn't confirm. Not "there's a lot more to understand". The actual gap you hit.

I went looking for

and couldn't confirm it because

Only using this component? Go to the Look back pages now (R-E1-E3, in Closing).

Using more? Clip this page to Before Component 1 (R-1A). Component 2 starts next.

Two ways to use it

Every tool in this component works on paper or with cards. The questions are the same, and so is what you end up with. Pick what suits your group, or mix the two.

The paper way

Print the blank template for each tool, or copy it onto a big sheet. Write everything on sticky notes.

BEST FOR

Working alone or in pairs. A first try.
Little time.

YOU NEED

This booklet, a printer, sticky notes in three colours.

The card way

Lay a big board on the table. Printed cards hold the categories and questions. What you find goes on yellow evidence cards or sticky notes.

BEST FOR

Teams of 3–5, workshops, and sessions with participants. Cards get moved, argued over, reshuffled.

YOU NEED

The card kit: boards printed large, card sheets printed and cut (p.1.12).

WHICH PAGES FOR WHICH TOOL

TOOL	PAPER • PRINT THESE	CARD KIT • BOARD + CARDS
 Media & Gossip	1.03 · 1.04	B1, B2 · S1, S2
 History	1.05	B3 · S1, S3
 The Break	1.06 · 1.07	B4, B5 · S1, S4, S5, S6
 Power	1.08	B6 · S1, S3, S7
 Synthesis	1.09	B7 · S8

Using the kit? On every template, a green tag like  **S2 CHANNEL** shows which card goes where, and

 **CARD KIT Board B1** tells you which board to lay out.

NEXT PAGE **The card kit →**

The card kit

The same tools, laid out on a table. Printed cards hold the categories and the questions. What you find goes on yellow evidence cards or sticky notes.

WHAT'S INSIDE

	Evidence · anything you saw, heard or found. Every tool.	S1
	Channel · where a quote came from. Tool 1.	S2
	Question · answer it on a teal note. Several tools.	S2 S3 S5
	People · roles around the product. Tools 2 and 4.	S3
	Need, four suits · people, objects, systems, information. Tool 3.	S4
	Failure + blame tokens · what goes wrong at a step, and where the blame lands. Tool 3.	S5
	Constraint · the one hard limit you give your persona. Tool 3.	S6
	Lens + Finding · three ways to read power, and findings to rate. Tool 4.	S7
	Synthesis · one line per tool, three redesigns, the claim.	S8

PRINT THE CARDS

Sheets S1–S8 (p.113–1.20) on A4 card, 250–300 gsm. Cut along the dashed lines. Print S1 five times and S4 twice. The rest once.

PRINT THE BOARDS

Boards B1–B7 (p.1.21–1.27) at A2, landscape. A3 works for pairs. No big printer? Copy the board onto chart paper.

SET UP THE TABLE

- 1 Put one board in the middle. Only the one for the tool you're doing.
- 2 Sort the cards face up by colour, along the edge of the table.
- 3 Keep sticky notes and pens out. You still write on notes.
- 4 Photograph the board before you clear it. The photo is your record.

A card is a prompt, not evidence. Everything you put on a board has to come from something real you saw, heard or found.

Evidence cards

PRINT ×5 ON CARD

Cut along the dashed lines

EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE
EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE
EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE	EVIDENCES1 What I saw or heard WHERE · CHANNEL WHO DATE TOOL ☐ SEEN ☐ HEARD ☐ ONLINE

Channel + question cards

Cut along the dashed lines

CHANNEL	TOOL 1 · S2	CHANNEL	TOOL 1 · S2	CHANNEL	TOOL 1 · S2
Ad or poster TV, print, hoardings, social media ads, launch videos.  Lay it in circle ① Media story PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.	Official page App store listing, website, scheme notice, press release.  Lay it in circle ① Media story PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.	FAQ or support reply Help pages, replies to complaints, emails from the helpdesk.  Lay it in circle ② Official feedback PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.	Public review App store and Google reviews, where the company can reply.  Lay it in circle ② Official feedback PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.	Forum or comments Reddit, Quora, YouTube comments, Facebook groups.  Lay it in circle ③ Gossip PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.	Chat or word of mouth Forwards, what seniors say, what people told you in interviews.  Lay it in circle ③ Gossip PUT THE QUOTES YOU FIND FROM THIS CHANNEL NEXT TO IT. NOTE THE CHANNEL ON EACH.
QUESTION	TOOL 1 · S2	QUESTION	TOOL 1 · S2	QUESTION	TOOL 1 · S2
GOSSIP ONLY Why can't this be said officially? _____ _____ _____ ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.	THE CENTRE · ALL THREE Why hasn't it been fixed? Who gains? _____ _____ _____ ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.	FOLK FIXES What workaround do seniors pass on? _____ _____ _____ ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.			

People + question cards

Cut along the dashed lines

PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 An official or clerk Checked the papers. Could sometimes make an exception. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed	PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 A teacher or principal Signed, verified, reminded, chased. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed	PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 A family member Parent, sibling, spouse. Holds a phone, a document or the money. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed
PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 A local shop Cybercafé, photocopy or recharge shop. Paid by the user. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed	PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 An agent or middleman Fills forms or “fixes” problems for a fee. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed	PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 A friend or senior Passes on how it's really done. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed
PEOPLE TOOLS 2 + 4 · S3 Someone else Write the role. WHO, EXACTLY _____ TOOL 2 · HISTORY ☐ Then ☐ Now ☐ Lost a role ☐ Gained one TOOL 4 · UNPAID HELPER ☐ Paid by it ☐ Credited ☐ Needed	QUESTION TOOL 2 · S3 TOOL 2 · HISTORY What did it remove that people used to be able to do? _____ _____ _____ ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.	QUESTION TOOL 2 · S3 TOOL 2 · HISTORY Which power stayed the same, in a new form? _____ _____ _____ ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.

Need cards · four suits

PEOPLE S4 WHO MUST HELP? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	PEOPLE S4 WHO MUST HELP? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	PEOPLE S4 WHO MUST HELP? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	PEOPLE S4 WHO MUST HELP? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER
PEOPLE S4 WHO MUST HELP? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	OBJECTS S4 WHAT MUST THEY OWN? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	OBJECTS S4 WHAT MUST THEY OWN? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	OBJECTS S4 WHAT MUST THEY OWN? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER
OBJECTS S4 WHAT MUST THEY OWN? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	OBJECTS S4 WHAT MUST THEY OWN? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	SYSTEMS S4 WHAT ELSE MUST WORK? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	SYSTEMS S4 WHAT ELSE MUST WORK? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER
SYSTEMS S4 WHAT ELSE MUST WORK? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	SYSTEMS S4 WHAT ELSE MUST WORK? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	SYSTEMS S4 WHAT ELSE MUST WORK? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	INFORMATION S4 WHAT MUST THEY KNOW? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER
INFORMATION S4 WHAT MUST THEY KNOW? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	INFORMATION S4 WHAT MUST THEY KNOW? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	INFORMATION S4 WHAT MUST THEY KNOW? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER	INFORMATION S4 WHAT MUST THEY KNOW? STEP __ ☐ LEFT TO USER

Failure cards, blame tokens, questions

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

System failure

Something in the Systems row doesn't work: the server, the SMS, the match.

Look at the **Systems** row on your flow.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

Person unavailable

Someone from the People row isn't there when they're needed.

Look at the **People** row on your flow.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

Object missing

Something from the Objects row isn't at hand, or doesn't work.

Look at the **Objects** row on your flow.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

Information gap

They don't know it, and the product doesn't say.

Look at the **Information** row on your flow.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

No time

Everything is there, except the time the step demands.

Look at the **All rows** rows on your flow.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

FAILURETOOL 3 • S5

Another failure

Something that breaks, but isn't on the other cards.

STEP _____

LIKELY _____ /10

AT EACH STEP, DRAW THE LIKELIEST FAILURE

BLAME TOKENSTOOL 3 • S5

1

Where the user puts the blame

2

Where the product's words put it

★

Where it belongs

CUT OUT THE THREE ROUND TOKENS

QUESTIONTOOL 3 • S5

VILLAIN STORY

Does the person know they're the exception?

ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.

QUESTIONTOOL 3 • S5

VILLAIN STORY

Is the workaround dignified?

ANSWER ON A TEAL NOTE. PLACE IT NEXT TO THIS CARD.

COMPONENT 1 • CARD KIT

1.17

Constraint cards · for your villain persona

Cut along the dashed lines

CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 Shared phone The phone belongs to someone else in the family. So do the OTPs. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 Only a phone camera No scanner, no printer, no laptop. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 Patchy network Signal comes and goes. The data pack runs out mid-month. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.
CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 A different language Comfortable in a language the product doesn't use. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 No free time Works or studies long hours. Free only late at night. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 A missing document One paper is lost, expired, or in a slightly different name. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.
CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 Needs permission Someone else has to agree before they can act. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 The deadline is close One try left before it closes. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.	CONSTRAINT TOOL 3 · S6 Your own A hard limit you saw in the field. GIVE YOUR PERSONA ONE. ONLY ONE.

Lens + finding cards

Cut along the dashed lines

LENS TOOL 4 · S7 Creator lens 1 Who built it? 2 Were they rushing, saving money or ticking boxes? 3 Find three moments where it shows. ANSWERS ON TEAL NOTES, BESIDE THIS CARD	LENS TOOL 4 · S7 Authority lens 1 Where is the most friction? 2 Whom does it protect? 3 How many steps to reach a human? Whose name is in the error? ANSWERS ON TEAL NOTES, BESIDE THIS CARD	LENS TOOL 4 · S7 Political lens 1 More independent, or more dependent? 2 What must users hand over? Where does it go? 3 What would it have to stop doing? ANSWERS ON TEAL NOTES, BESIDE THIS CARD
FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL	FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL	FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL
FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL	FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL	FINDING TOOL 4 · S7 Finding PLACE IT UNDER MINOR, MAJOR OR CRITICAL

Synthesis cards

SYNTHESIS S8 ONE LINE FROM Media POINTS TO CARD EVERY LINE MUST POINT TO A CARD	SYNTHESIS S8 ONE LINE FROM Gossip POINTS TO CARD EVERY LINE MUST POINT TO A CARD	SYNTHESIS S8 ONE LINE FROM History POINTS TO CARD EVERY LINE MUST POINT TO A CARD
SYNTHESIS S8 ONE LINE FROM Power POINTS TO CARD EVERY LINE MUST POINT TO A CARD	SYNTHESIS S8 ONE LINE FROM Villain ★ POINTS TO CARD EVERY LINE MUST POINT TO A CARD	REDESIGN S8 A REDESIGN A SPECIFIC SCREEN OR STEP GAINS RESISTS PLACE IT ON THE BLAME SCALE, BOARD B7
REDESIGN S8 B REDESIGN A SPECIFIC SCREEN OR STEP GAINS RESISTS PLACE IT ON THE BLAME SCALE, BOARD B7	REDESIGN S8 C REDESIGN A SPECIFIC SCREEN OR STEP GAINS RESISTS PLACE IT ON THE BLAME SCALE, BOARD B7	CLAIM S8 The design claim We should redesign _____ , because it would shift blame from _____ to _____ , and would specifically help _____ . EVERY BLANK MUST POINT TO A CARD

The Media Story

The person in the ads

AGE _____ PLACE _____

DEVICE _____ MOOD _____

STICK A SCREENSHOT OF THE AD

Your real user

AGE _____ PLACE _____

DEVICE _____ MOOD _____

STICK A PHOTO OR SKETCH, WITH CONSENT

PRODUCT _____

- 1 Spend 15 minutes with real ads and notices.
- 2 Fill both people. Then A–D on yellow cards, numbered by prompt.

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S1 Evidence

A What it claims

- 1 Its main promise, in its own words
- 2 A word the ads keep using that the product doesn't live up to
- 3 How a user would describe it to a friend

B The story it sells

- 1 Where the ads' story starts
- 2 Where it ends
- 3 What it skips

C What the designers meant

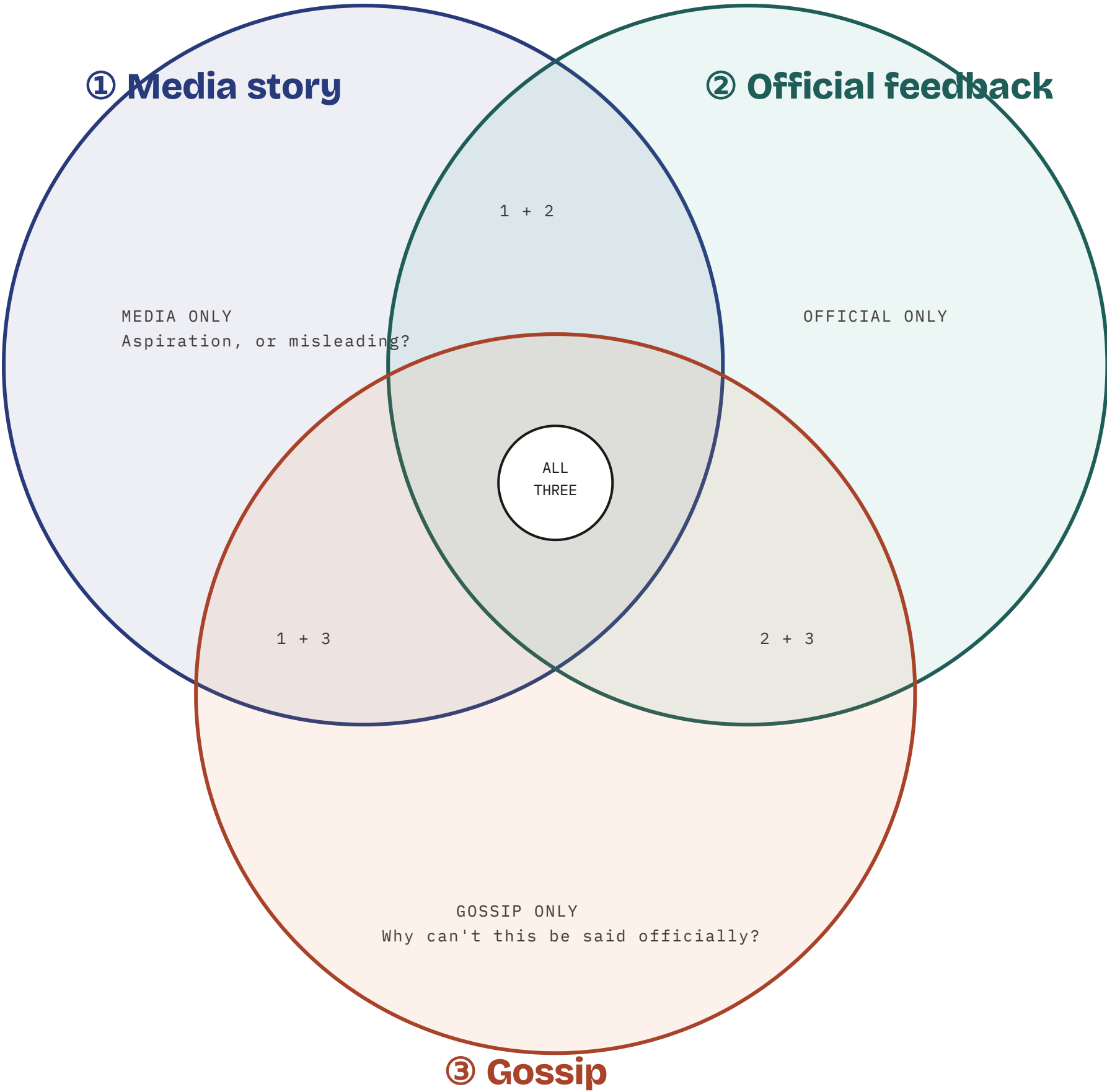
- 1 The problem the designers set out to solve, in their own words
- 2 The user they imagined
- 3 What they designed against, and its cost

D How users experience it

- 1 First time (signing up)
- 2 Using it (the main task)
- 3 Afterwards (waiting, coming back)

The Gossip Venn

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S1 Evidence · S2 Channels + questions



ASK OF EACH ZONE

Centre. Why hasn't it been fixed? Who gains?

Tone. Which words vanish in official channels?

Folk fixes. What workaround do seniors pass on?

★ HARDEST CONTRADICTION · KEEP FOR SYNTHESIS

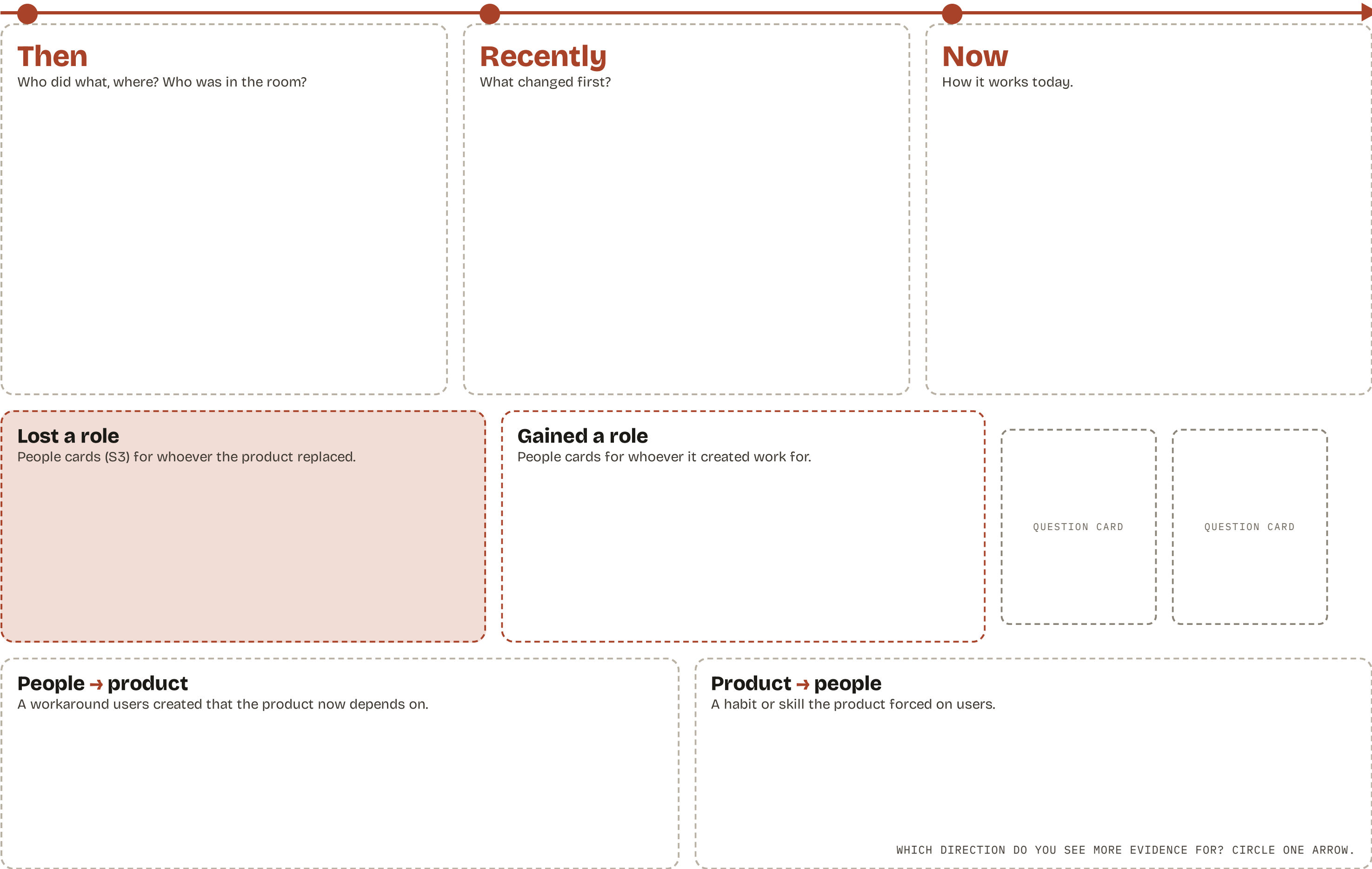
Which two circles clash most?

- 1 Channel cards (S2) go in their circles.
- 2 Quotes on yellow cards, next to their channel.
- 3 Overlaps matter most. Move cards as you argue.
- 4 Question cards: answer on teal notes.

The timeline

- 1
- Talk to someone who did it before it went digital.
- 2
- Notes on the timeline. Move People cards to lost or gained.
- 3
- Put each change on its arrow. Answer the question cards.

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S1 Evidence · S3 People + questions



Ideal flow + needs

FEATURE _____ GOAL _____

- 1 Steps on orange notes. Then need cards (S4) under each step.
- 2 Fill the dot on every need left for the user to solve.

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S4 Need cards

	STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	STEP 4	STEP 5	STEP 6
PEOPLE Who must help?						
OBJECTS What must they own?						
SYSTEMS What else must work?						
INFORMATION What must they know?						
WHO THIS WAS DESIGNED FOR · DEVICE, TIME, SKILLS, WHO THEY CAN CALL						
☐ Left to the user: ____ of ____ needs						

Villain walk + Blame Scale

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S5 Failure, tokens · S6 Constraints

The villain persona

Very unlike the ideal user.

NAME _____

CONTEXT _____

CONSTRAINT CARD ·
S6

- 1 Draw one constraint card for the persona.
- 2 Walk them through each step. Draw the likeliest failure card.
- 3 Write what broke and who pays. Star the likeliest break.
- 4 Take the starred step to the Blame Scale.

QUESTION CARD

QUESTION CARD

STEP _____



FAILURE CARD

WHAT BROKE · WORKAROUND

LIKELY _____ /10

WHO PAYS _____

STEP _____



FAILURE CARD

WHAT BROKE · WORKAROUND

LIKELY _____ /10

WHO PAYS _____

STEP _____



FAILURE CARD

WHAT BROKE · WORKAROUND

LIKELY _____ /10

WHO PAYS _____

STEP _____



FAILURE CARD

WHAT BROKE · WORKAROUND

LIKELY _____ /10

WHO PAYS _____

STEP _____



FAILURE CARD

WHAT BROKE · WORKAROUND

LIKELY _____ /10

WHO PAYS _____

The Blame Scale

Place tokens 1, 2 and ★ (S5) on the line.

STEP _____

Self · “my fault”

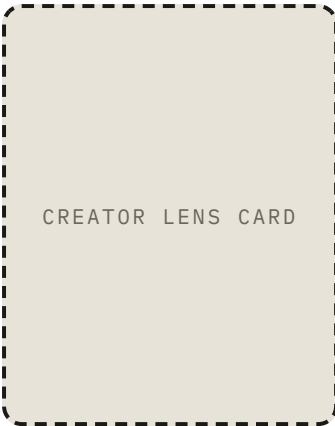
System · “its fault”

The gap is the distance between what this product _____ and what it should have _____.

Three lenses + findings

- 1
- Choose: this product live, or 2–3 similar ones.
- 2
- Read it through each lens card. Answers on teal notes.
- 3
- Rate every finding by where you put it.

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S3 People · S7 Lens + findings



Creator
Who built it, and what did they rush?



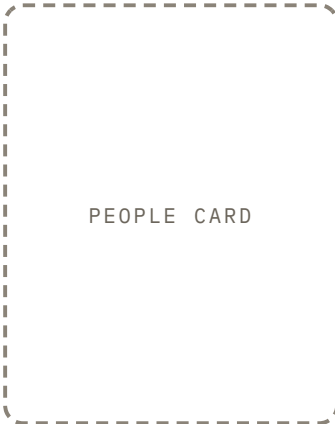
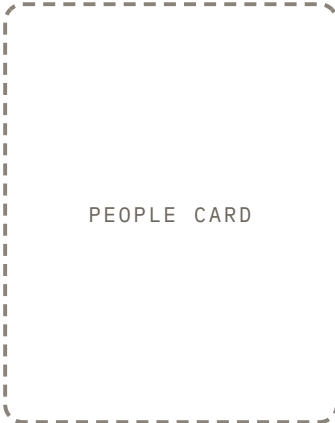
Authority
What is the institution really guarding against?



Political
More independent, or more dependent?

Unpaid helpers

Who does work to make it function, without being paid or credited by it? People cards (S3).



Findings

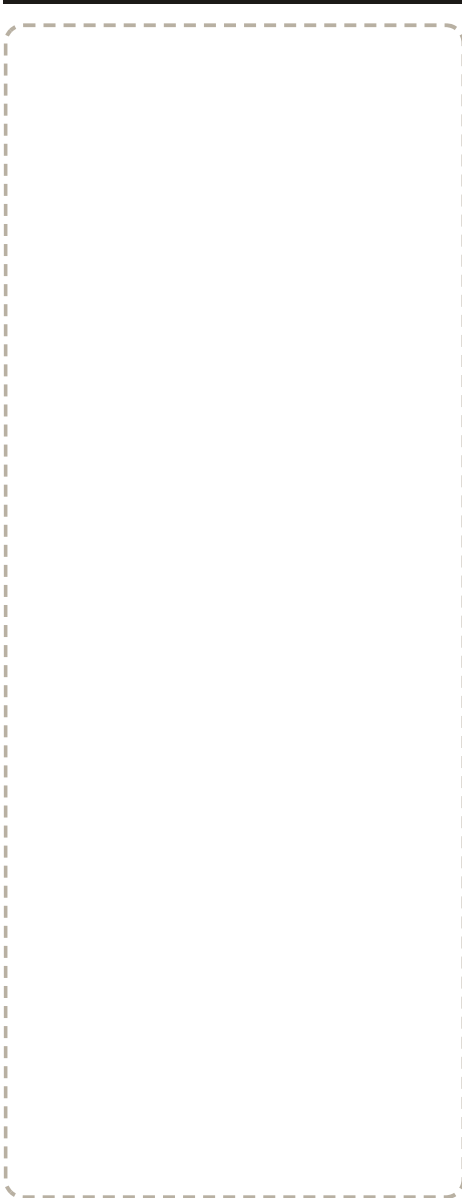
Each finding: a quote or observation

Place each finding card (S7) by how serious it is.

MINOR

MAJOR

CRITICAL



Synthesis

PRINT A2 LANDSCAPE · A3 FOR PAIRS
Cards: S8 Synthesis · all cards from Tools 1–4

1 · ONE LINE FROM EACH TOOL

MEDIA

GOSSIP

HISTORY

POWER

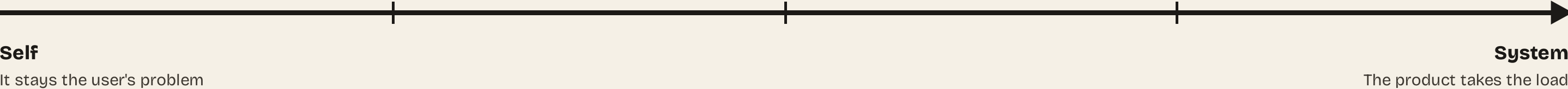
VILLAIN ★

2 · THE SHARPEST CONTRADICTION

“The product claims _____
, but _____ revealed
_____.”

3 + 4 · THREE REDESIGNS ON THE BLAME SCALE

Place cards A, B, C (S8) on the line. Which one moves the blame furthest toward the system?



5 · POWER TEST

“If this were built, _____ would gain
_____. And _____ would resist it
because _____.”

6 · THE FINDING

“This product assumes _____, but the user
actually has _____, which causes _____
.”

CLAIM CARD

7 · THE DESIGN CLAIM

Fill the claim card last. Every blank must
point to a card already on this board.

Reading Visual Culture

What have people learned to notice, trust and act on, before they even touch your product?



4 TOOLS

ABOUT A WEEK, 3 SESSIONS

PARTICIPANT-LED • IMAGE-FIRST

What is this component?

Designers usually start with an imagined user and read everything through them. This component flips the order. **The participant shows what the situation actually looks like, in their own world, before the designer explains it.**

The participant decides what matters in the picture.

Visual culture is not how things look. It's what people have learned to recognise, trust, ignore and act on.

NOT A PERSONA...

A persona asks **who**.

...A CONTEXT SCENARIO

Asks who, **where, when, under what conditions, with what information and whose help.**

EVERY CLAIM CARRIES AN EVIDENCE STATUS

OBSERVED

Visible in the image or the moment.

REPORTED

The participant said it.

INFERRED

Our reading of the evidence.

HYPOTHESISED

A possibility we still need to check.

One photo is a situation. Repeated photos are a pattern. A pattern the participants also describe is a stronger claim. **Never make a cultural claim from a single image.**

THE ROUTE

1 Show

a week

→

2 Read

60-90 min

→

3 Build

45 min

→

4 Hand off

30 min

You need: 3-6 participants with camera phones, consent to use their photos, a printer, a big table or wall. **Short on time?** Go straight to the templates (2.05, 2.08, 2.11, 2.14). Each has [bracketed] examples.

BEFORE COMPONENT 2

R·2A

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 1-2 · POSITION + PREDICTION · FILL BEFORE 2.03 SHOW

COMPONENT 2 · READING VISUAL CULTURE

Before I begin,
I want to make my starting position visible.

1 POSITION

Your device. Your language at home. Your city.

Device _____

Language at home _____

City _____

Have you used this product, avoided it, or never needed it?

☐

Used it

☐

Avoided it

☐

Never needed it

Because _____

What else might shape how you see this person or product?

2 PREDICTION

FOR THIS COMPONENT, PREDICT

which images people will trust, which they will ignore, and why.

What do you expect to find?

Why do you expect to find that?

What do you think it could mean? What do you already know about this context that is making you predict this?

Keep this page visible while you work. Do not change the prediction until the component is complete.

WHEN THE COMPONENT IS DONE
AFTER COMPONENT 2 · R·2B

Show

What does the moment actually look like, in their world?

🕒 A WEEK TO CAPTURE 30 MIN BRIEF • 45 MIN TALK-BACK EFFORT ●●○ PARTICIPANTS' PHONES

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Where people really learn, check, convert and get help, seen through their own camera.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every photo has the three answers written beside it, in the participant's own words.

WHAT IS IT?

Give participants six photo missions. They photograph their own world for a week. Then you sit with them and ask the same three questions about every photo, so you never have to guess what an image means.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Mission	One photo brief, like "Show me what you keep beside you."
Three questions	What is this? Why did you show us this? What were you doing?
Capture rule	Never show example photos first. Examples steer what people shoot.
Own words	Answers can be written in any language or script.

YOU NEED

Participants with camera phones, the mission cards (p.2.05), consent for their photos

YOU'LL END UP WITH

A wall of captioned photos, each tagged Observed or Reported, for Tool 2

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's photos →**

Meera's photos, one per mission

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN

M01 <i>Screenshot of a class WhatsApp group: a forwarded notice with the last date circled.</i> Where you learn WHAT IS THIS? Class group message. WHY SHOW US? This is where I found out. Not the website. DOING? Checking the last date again. REPORTED	M02 <i>A notebook page with user ID, password and application number in pen, next to her phone.</i> What you keep beside you WHAT IS THIS? My notebook. WHY SHOW US? I write the IDs here. The SMS gets deleted. DOING? Logging in. OBSERVED	M03 <i>The cybercafé counter. The owner's hand on the mouse, her certificate on the scanner.</i> Who or what helps WHAT IS THIS? Bhaiya ki dukaan. WHY SHOW US? "Unko setting pata hai" (he knows the setting). DOING? Making the file small. REPORTED
M04 <i>Three steps in one frame: paper certificate, its phone photo, the PDF on the café screen.</i> When information changes WHAT IS THIS? My certificate becoming a PDF. WHY SHOW US? It changes three times before it's accepted. DOING? Converting. OBSERVED	M05 <i>Her father's phone on a shelf at home, with a paper slip that says "OTP" in her writing.</i> When the expected way fails WHAT IS THIS? Papa's phone. WHY SHOW US? The OTP goes here, not to me. DOING? Waiting for him to call back. REPORTED	M06 <i>The portal page. Her finger on the small red "Pending" next to the government emblem.</i> What you know to look at WHAT IS THIS? The emblem and the status. WHY SHOW US? If it has the emblem, it's real. Red means something's wrong. DOING? Checking if it's fake. REPORTED

TO COMPONENT 3 "Setting" came up in her own words. Log it for thick translation in Reading Language, Tool 2.

Illustrative example. Photos are described, not shown. Use your participants' real photos, with consent.

How to use it

[Next page · Blank template →](#)

1

Hand out the six missions. Show no example photos.

2

Give them a week. Any number of photos per mission.

3

Talk-back: ask the three questions about every photo.

4

Write their answers in their words, any language.

5

Tag each answer Observed or Reported. Print photos small.

Mission cards + photo slips

BLANK TEMPLATE

Print on card. Cut out. Give one set to each participant. Print a photo slip for every photo at the talk-back.

MISSION 01 C2 • SHOW Show me where you learn Something that helps you know what to do: a message, notice, document, person, screenshot, note, or something else. → What did this help you understand?	MISSION 02 C2 • SHOW Show me what you keep beside you Not the task. What is around it: anything you keep close to complete, understand or check it. → Why do you need this?	MISSION 03 C2 • SHOW Show me who or what helps Whatever helps when something becomes unclear or difficult: a person, message, screen, object, place or route. → What would you have done without it?
MISSION 04 C2 • SHOW Show me when information changes Follow information as it changes form: one format, language, screen or document becoming another. → What changed before you could use it?	MISSION 05 C2 • SHOW Show me when the expected way doesn't work Don't just show the problem. Show what you did instead: another person, device, place or attempt. → What made you do this instead?	MISSION 06 C2 • SHOW Show me what you know to look at Something you look for before deciding what to do, what to trust or what to ignore. → How did you learn that this mattered?

PHOTO NO. ___ . M__ ANSWER IN ANY LANGUAGE OR SCRIPT What is this? Why did you show us this? What were you doing? TAG OBSERVED REPORTED	PHOTO NO. ___ . M__ ANSWER IN ANY LANGUAGE OR SCRIPT What is this? Why did you show us this? What were you doing? TAG OBSERVED REPORTED
---	---

NEXT **Tool 2 • Read →**

Read

What keeps happening, and what makes it possible?

🕒 60-90 MIN TEAM OF 2-4 EFFORT ●●● A BIG TABLE OR WALL

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Patterns across everyone's photos, what each pattern depends on, and where the product shows it differently.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every cluster has been through all three passes, and every claim has an evidence status.

WHAT IS IT?

Lay every photo on the table. Sort them three times, each time asking a different question. Group first, name second. Then test each cluster against nine structures, as questions, never as boxes to sort into.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Pass 1	What is happening? Same action or moment.
Pass 2	What is making it possible? Ignore the action.
Pass 3	What does the product show differently?
Structure	A question to test a cluster: social, material, linguistic...
Stop rule	A question that only gives an assumption is marked Hypothesised.

YOU NEED

All the captioned photos from Tool 1, sticky notes in three colours, the product open

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Named clusters, what enables them, and the gaps, for Tool 3

NEXT PAGE **Example • Three passes →**

Three passes over the photos

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN

PASS 1 · WHAT IS HAPPENING?

Checking 0 M1 M6 P2·4	Converting 0 M3 M4 P3·2	Waiting 0 M5 P4·1	Keeping records 0 M2 P2·6
--	--	--	--

PASS 2 · WHAT MAKES IT POSSIBLE?

Checking A class WhatsApp group · a senior · the emblem R

Converting A cybercafé · ₹30–50 · the owner's know-how R

Waiting Father's phone · father's free time R

Keeping records A paper notebook · a pen 0

PASS 3 · WHAT DOES THE PRODUCT SHOW DIFFERENTLY?

PRODUCT SHOWS "Upload your documents (PDF, max 200KB)." 	PHOTOS SHOW A paper certificate, photographed, carried to a café, converted by someone else. 	WHAT CHANGED Format, place and person. Three steps the product calls one. I
---	--	--

STRUCTURES TESTED · SHADED ONES HELD UP FOR THIS CLUSTER

Social Who else must be involved?	Institutional Who has permission to resolve this?	Knowledge What had to be known already?	Material What physical thing had to exist?	Economic Did making this work cost anything?
Linguistic Did meaning change as information moved?	Authority What makes one version trustworthy?	Risk What happens if they get it wrong?	Adaptation What did they change to make it work?	

Illustrative example. P2–P4 are other participants.

How to use it

[Next page · Blank template →](#)

1

Lay every photo out. Group by action only.

2

Regroup: what is present that makes it possible?

3

Put the product's version next to each cluster.

4

Ask the nine structures as questions.

5

Tag every claim. Unsupported ones become Hypothesised.

Three passes

BLANK TEMPLATE

PASS 1

What is happening?

Group photos by the same action or moment. Ignore who is in them.

PASS 2

What makes it possible?

Person, document, device, place, knowledge, connection, money, time, authority, routine.

PASS 3

Product shows → photos show

What is missing, simplified or changed between them?

The product shows

["upload a PDF"], but the

photos show

[a printout taken to a café]. What

changed:

[format, place, person]

STRUCTURES TO TEST, AS QUESTIONS

Social

Who else must be involved?

Institutional

Who has permission to resolve this?

Knowledge

What had to be known already?

Material

What physical thing had to exist?

Economic

Did making this work cost anything?

Linguistic

Did meaning change as information moved?

Authority

What makes one version trustworthy?

Risk

What happens if they get it wrong?

Adaptation

What did they change to make it work?

STOP

If a question only produces an assumption, mark it **HYPOTHESED**. Don't put it in the scenario until the evidence supports it.

NEXT **Tool 3 • Build →**

Build

What situation are we actually designing for?

🕒 45 MIN PAIR OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

One real situation: the moment, what the person sees, where information comes from, who helps, and what breaks.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

All nine boxes are filled from evidence, or honestly left as "unknown".

WHAT IS IT?

Turn the clusters into a Context Scenario. Nine boxes, each answered only from the photos, the talk-backs and repeated patterns. Paste photos straight onto the sheet.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Context Scenario	A situation, not a persona. Who, where, when, what conditions.
Condition	The combination that keeps appearing: timing + a person + a thing.
Hidden work	What happens outside the product that nobody designed.
Edge-case check	"This was treated as ____, but the evidence shows ____."

YOU NEED

Your clusters from Tool 2, 3–5 printed photos, glue

YOU'LL END UP WITH

One Context Scenario to design against, for Tool 4

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's scenario →**

A Context Scenario

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

01 • THE MOMENT R**What is actually happening?**

Exam week, 9 pm. Uploading the income certificate two days before the deadline.

02 • THE WORLD AROUND THEM O**What do they see?**

A class WhatsApp thread, a notebook of IDs, a phone at 12%. The portal comes last.

03 • INFORMATION JOURNEY R**Where does it come from?**

Notice → class group → senior → Meera → café owner → portal.

04 • THE VISUAL CUE R**What tells them what to trust?**

The government emblem. Red text means “something is wrong”.

05 • PEOPLE AROUND THEM R**Who else is involved?**

A senior (explains), the café owner (converts), her father (holds the OTP).

06 • WHAT THEY ALREADY KNOW I**What does it assume?**

What a PDF is, which number is registered, that “pending” can mean weeks.

07 • THE HIDDEN WORK O**What happens off-screen?**

Photographing, travelling, paying ₹30–50, waiting for a call back.

08 • THE CONDITION I**What combination keeps appearing?**

Deadline pressure + a paper document + a helper with a device + someone else's phone.

09 • THE CONSEQUENCE R**What breaks if one condition goes?**

No café open at night → no PDF → misses the deadline. Seen in 2 of 4 participants.

EDGE-CASE CHECK

This was treated as “a student with a slow internet connection”, but the evidence shows an upload that needs three places and two other people.

THE VISUAL READING

She has learned to trust the emblem and the class group, and to distrust anything red, before she reads a single word.

Illustrative example.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Answer box 01 first. Be specific about time and pressure.

2

Paste 3–5 photos into box 02.

3

Draw the information journey as arrows.

4

Tag every box. Leave unknowns as “unknown”.

5

Write the edge-case check and the visual reading.

Context Scenario

BLANK TEMPLATE

01 • THE MOMENT

What is actually happening?

[exam week, 9 pm, uploading two days before the deadline]

02 • THE WORLD AROUND THEM

What do they see?

[class WhatsApp, a notebook of IDs, phone at 12%]

03 • INFORMATION JOURNEY

Where does it come from?

[notice] → *[class group]* →
[senior] → action

04 • THE VISUAL CUE

What tells them what to trust?

[the emblem = official; red text = something's wrong]

05 • PEOPLE AROUND THEM

Who else is involved?

[senior explains; café owner converts; father holds the OTP]

06 • WHAT THEY ALREADY KNOW

What does it assume?

[what a PDF is; which number is registered]

07 • THE HIDDEN WORK

What happens off-screen?

[photographing, travelling, paying ₹30–50, waiting]

08 • THE CONDITION

What combination keeps appearing?

[deadline] + *[paper document]* +
[a helper]

09 • THE CONSEQUENCE

What breaks if one condition goes?

[no café open at night → no PDF → missed deadline]

EDGE-CASE CHECK

This was treated as _____, but the evidence shows

_____.

THE VISUAL READING • WHAT HAVE THEY LEARNED TO NOTICE, TRUST, IGNORE OR ACT ON, AND WHEN?

NEXT **Tool 4 • Hand off →**

Hand off

What does this tell us about the system, not the person?

🕒 30 MIN PAIR OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What the person does in this situation, what the system has failed to make visible, and which component to take it to next.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

You have one traceable sentence where every blank points to a photo or a quote.

WHAT IS IT?

Fill a Context Profile: short verbs for what the person does in this situation. Then turn each observation about the person into a question about the system. Finish with one traceable statement and hand it off.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Context Profile	Trying to, depends on, checks, converts, works around...
Don't conclude	A claim about the person: "students depend on seniors."
Ask instead	A question about the system: "what does the senior know that the system hides?"
Hand off	Where the reading goes next.

YOU NEED

Your Context Scenario from Tool 3

YOU'LL END UP WITH

One traceable statement, handed to Component 1, 3 or 4

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's profile →**

Context Profile + the reading

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

When Meera is uploading documents at night, before a deadline...

TRYING TO
submit before the
deadline

DEPENDS ON
a café, a senior, Papa's
phone

ALREADY KNOWS
the emblem means
official

DOESN'T KNOW YET
how to make a PDF

ASKS
her senior, before
submitting

CONVERTS
paper → photo → PDF

CHECKS
the class group for
dates

WORKS AROUND
the OTP by calling home
dates

RISKS
her data with a stranger

DOES INSTEAD
a trip to the café

HAS ACCESS TO
a phone, not a scanner

ALMOST CALLED "EXTRA"
the notebook of IDs

PERSON
"I ask my senior before
submitting."

DON'T CONCLUDE
~~Students depend on seniors.~~

ASK INSTEAD
What does the senior know that
the system hasn't made visible?

THE READING • ONE TRACEABLE STATEMENT

We observed **students converting paper documents through a café** in **night-time, deadline** conditions (M3, M4, P3-2). This matters because **the upload step assumes a scanner and a PDF**. The existing product currently **calls this one step**. This makes us investigate **whether the product can accept a phone photo**.

→ HANDS OFF TO
1 • Existing Products
Can the product work under this
condition?

→ HANDS OFF TO
3 • Reading Language
What does "setting" really mean
here?

→ HANDS OFF TO
4 • Material Reality
What does the café trip cost her?

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Write the
situation on top:
"When ____ is
____..."

2

Fill each verb
from evidence
only.

3

Rewrite every
person-claim as a
system question.

4

Write the reading.
Cite a photo or
quote per blank.

5

Pick the
component it
goes to next.

Context Profile + the reading

BLANK TEMPLATE

When _____ is in this situation: _____...

TRYING TO <i>[submit before the deadline]</i>	DEPENDS ON <i>[a café, a senior, Papa's phone]</i>	ALREADY KNOWS <i>[the emblem means official]</i>	DOESN'T KNOW YET <i>[how to make a PDF]</i>
ASKS <i>[her senior, before submitting]</i>	CONVERTS (CHANGES THE FORMAT) <i>[paper → photo → PDF]</i>	CHECKS <i>[the class group for dates]</i>	WORKS AROUND <i>[the OTP by calling home]</i>
RISKS <i>[her data with a stranger]</i>	DOES INSTEAD <i>[a trip to the café]</i>	HAS ACCESS TO <i>[a phone, not a scanner]</i>	TREATED AS "EXTRA", BUT NEEDED <i>[the notebook of IDs]</i>

PERSON / SITUATION <i>["I ask my senior before submitting."]</i>	DON'T CONCLUDE · A CLAIM ABOUT THE PERSON <i>[students depend on seniors]</i>	ASK INSTEAD What does <u><i>[the senior]</i></u> know that the system hasn't made visible?
---	--	---

THE READING

We observed _____ in _____ conditions. This matters because _____. The existing product currently _____. This makes us investigate _____.

HANDS OFF TO ☐ 1 · Existing Products ☐ 3 · Language ☐ 4 · Material Reality

NEXT **Is it working? →**

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

- ✓ A photo surprised you: it showed a step the product doesn't know exists.
- ✓ Participants named things you would never have photographed.
- ✓ Your clusters are actions, not kinds of people.
- ✓ Every box in the scenario has a tag, and some say "unknown".

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ Every photo looks like your own guesses.
You showed examples first, or explained what a "good" photo is. Run the missions again, cold.
- ✗ A cluster is named after a group of people.
Regroup by action. "Seniors" is not a cluster; "asking before submitting" is.
- ✗ A scenario box has no photo or quote behind it.
Mark it Hypothesised, or take it back to a participant.
- ✗ Your reading describes the person, not the system.
Rewrite it as "the system hasn't made ____ visible".

What looks like an edge case from the interface may be an ordinary situation from the user's side.

AFTER COMPONENT 2

R·2B

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 3-4 · CLAIM + REDACTION · FILL RIGHT AFTER 2.15 IS IT WORKING?

COMPONENT 2 · READING VISUAL CULTURE

What did the process actually give me?
Not what I set out to find.

1 THE STANZA

Write one paragraph, not a list, about what you actually learned. Not what you set out to find. What the process gave you that you did not already have when you started.

2 REDACTION

Read your stanza back slowly. **Underline** anything that might come from your own familiarity, frustration or background rather than the evidence. What is left un-underlined is the part you can stand behind.

What's left that I can stand behind:

3 STILL UNKNOWN

Name one specific thing you went looking for and couldn't confirm. Not "there's a lot more to understand". The actual gap you hit.

I went looking for _____

and couldn't confirm it because _____

Only using this component? Go to the Look back pages now (R·E1-E3, in Closing).

Using more? Clip this page to Before Component 2 (R·2A). Component 3 starts next.

Reading Language

Don't only listen to what was said.
Understand what was meant.

ऊपर वाले
की मज़ी

LITERAL: "THE ONE
ABOVE'S WISH"

MEANT: "IT'S OUT OF
MY HANDS NOW"

5 TOOLS + BEFORE YOU START

A RECORDER

A LOCAL LANGUAGE COLLABORATOR

What is this component?

In India, people rarely mean exactly what the words say. A phrase can carry a different meaning depending on the language, the tone, the region, or a gesture that goes with it. **If we only translate word for word, we lose all of that.**

Thick translation, not word-for-word.

Keep the context and the feeling along with the words. Then test the meaning with people, in both directions, before any of it reaches a screen.

THE ROUTE, AND WHERE IT LOOPS BACK



THE END PRODUCT

A glossary where every phrase has a **literal** meaning and an **implied** one. The difference between them is the useful part.

WORKS WITH COMPONENT 2

Words from photo talk-backs come here.
Drawings from the Kahavat Relay go there.

You need: consent to record, a recorder, a local language collaborator, time to go back to people. **Short on time?** Go straight to the templates (3.07, 3.10, 3.12–3.13, 3.16, 3.19, 3.22). Each has [bracketed] examples.

Understand the context first.

Do this once per place, before Tool 1. It takes a few days. Skipping it is how researchers end up translating their own assumptions.

- ☐ **Set the research question, consent and deletion rules**
What you will record, who can hear it, and when it gets deleted.
- ☐ **Spend time with a local guide and varied local people**
Before any interview. Listen to how people talk to each other.
- ☐ **Notice routines, relationships, language, communication**
Who speaks first? Which language is used for what?
- ☐ **Record possible meanings and their limits**
Write down what a phrase might mean, and what you can't know yet.
- ☐ **Write your positionality note**
Below. Your language, your background, what you might mishear.
- ☐ **Build a provisional codebook, glossary and interview guide**
Provisional means it will change after Tool 2.

POSITIONALITY NOTE

Languages I speak, and how well

Where I grew up; where they grew up

What I might hear as "normal"

Words I tend to over-read

Who will help me when I don't understand

PROVISIONAL GLOSSARY • START IT HERE, CORRECT IT IN TOOL 2

WORD OR PHRASE, AS HEARD	MIGHT MEAN	CAN'T KNOW YET

NEXT PAGE **Tool 1 • Listen →**

BEFORE COMPONENT 3

R·3A

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 1-2 · POSITION + PREDICTION · FILL BEFORE 3.04 LISTEN

COMPONENT 3 · READING LANGUAGE

Before I begin,
I want to make my starting position visible.

1 POSITION

Your device. Your language at home. Your city.

Device _____

Language at home _____

City _____

Have you used this product, avoided it, or never needed it?

☐ Used it

☐ Avoided it

☐ Never needed it

Because _____

What else might shape how you see this person or product?

2 PREDICTION

FOR THIS COMPONENT, PREDICT

which words will mean something different from what they say.

What do you expect to find?

Why do you expect to find that?

What do you think it could mean? What do you already know about this context that is making you predict this?

Keep this page visible while you work. Do not change the prediction until the component is complete.

WHEN THE COMPONENT IS DONE
AFTER COMPONENT 3 · R·3B

Listen

What did they say, and what did they mean by it?

🕒 60-90 MIN PER PERSON

👤 RESEARCHER + NOTE-TAKER

🔴 EFFORT ●●●

📍 FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

The moments where words, voice and body don't match, and what the person says those moments meant.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every marked moment has a Meaning Card, and the person has corrected or confirmed it.

WHAT IS IT?

Read six cue cards before the interview. During it, mark only symbols and three words. Start with daily life, not the task. When something significant happens, make a Meaning Card: what was said, what you saw, what you think. Then ask them what it meant, and write down their correction.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Cue	A signal beyond words: a pause, a switch of language, a glance.
------------	---

Log	Symbols and three words only. No meaning during the interview.
------------	--

Meaning Card	Said · Observed · Inferred, plus their own correction.
---------------------	--

Probe	Hard to explain? Try a drawing or an idiom (Tool 5).
--------------	--

YOU NEED

Consent to record, the cue cards (p.3.05), a printed log, your provisional glossary

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Meaning Cards and key moments to transcribe, for Tool 2

NEXT PAGE

Prime · Six cue cards →

Prime: six cue cards

READ FIRST

Read these once before the session. During it, don't interpret. Just mark what you notice with a symbol.

CARD 01

Body & posture

Opening or closing as the topic changes. Taking less space often means deference, not agreement.

→ What makes this person comfortable, or guarded?

CARD 02

Pause & silence

A long pause is data. Does it cluster around one topic? Silence may be deference, not confusion.

→ Topics that make silence are often the ones design must address.

CARD 03

Language switching

A switch mid-sentence often marks a concept that doesn't translate. Write the word exactly.

→ Which language carries the real feeling?

CARD 04

Social dynamics

Who else is in the room? A glance before answering is seeking approval. Someone answering for them is hierarchy.

→ Who else has a stake? Are they in the design?

CARD 05

Voice & tone

Faster: anxious or rehearsed. Slower: choosing words. Quieter: shame or privacy. Rising at the end: "is this right?"

→ What do they most need, or fear, from the product?

CARD 06

Objects & environment

Reaching for an object to explain something means the object may be the real interface.

→ Photograph it, with consent. Take it to Component 2.

LOG SYMBOLS

◆ Body || Pause ⇄ Switch ◎ Gaze ■ Object ↑ Voice ~ Deflect
 ✕ Avoided

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's interview** →

Log + Meaning Card

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

LOG EXCERPT • THREE WORDS, NO MEANING YET

SYM	WHAT	QUICK LOG	TRIGGERED BY
↔	Hindi → English	"pending" · "status"	<i>Asked about the result</i>
	6 s pause	before "Papa ka phone"	<i>Asked who gets the OTP</i>
↓	voice drops	"upar wale ki marzi"	<i>Asked what happens next</i>
👁	looks at roommate	then answers	<i>Asked about the café</i>

MEANING CARD • FOR THE MOMENT MARKED ↓

SAID "Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi."	OBSERVED Voice drops. She looks at the floor. Laughs once, short.	INFERRED She feels she has no control over the result. Maybe also: officials, not God.
ASKED: WHAT DID THAT MOMENT MEAN TO YOU? "Not God exactly. Whoever checks it. I don't know who that is."	HER CORRECTION "Upar wale" here means an unknown official , not God. Send to Tool 2.	

Illustrative example. Always record the phrase in the language it was said in.

How to use it

[Next page • Blank template →](#)

1

Start with daily life. Let them get comfortable.

2

Mark cues with a symbol and three words.

3

Pick the strongest moments. Make a Meaning Card.

4

Ask what the moment meant to them.

5

Write their correction, even if it disagrees with you.

Log + Meaning Card

BLANK TEMPLATE

PARTICIPANT CODE

DATE · PLACE

LANGUAGES IN USE

WHO ELSE IS PRESENT

SYM	CUE	QUICK LOG · ≤ 3 WORDS	TRIGGERED BY
◆	Body		
	Pause		
↔	Switch		
🎯	Gaze		
■	Object		
↑	Voice		
~	Deflect		
✕	Avoided		

MEANING CARD · CUT OUT, ONE PER MOMENT

SAID · IN THEIR LANGUAGE

["Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi."]

OBSERVED

[voice drops; looks at the floor]

INFERRED

[feels she has no control]

WHAT DID THAT MOMENT MEAN TO YOU?

["Whoever checks it. I don't know who."]

THEIR CORRECTION OR DISAGREEMENT

["upar wale" = an unknown official, not God]

NEXT **Tool 2 · Translate →**

Translate

What does it really mean, and do other people read it the same way?

🕒 PART A 1 H • PART B A SURVEY WITH A LANGUAGE COLLABORATOR EFFORT ●●●

DESK, THEN FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

The literal meaning, the implied meaning, and whether people from the same audience read it the same way.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The phrase has been read back by other people, and it passes all four support checks, or it goes round again.

WHAT IS IT?

Part A • Thick translation: write the phrase as it was said, then its literal meaning, its meaning in context, alternatives and what it implies. A local collaborator reviews it. **Part B • Reverse thick translation:** take it back to other people from the same audience in a short survey, in three directions, and see if they read the meaning you wrote. Only then run the support check.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Literal meaning	A plain English translation of the words.
Implied meaning	What the person really meant, including tone and feeling. The gap between the two is the useful part.
Reverse thick translation	Checking your reading with new people, not the person who said it.
Small signals	"Arre", "haaye", a laugh, a tone. Normal surveys drop these; record them.
Support check	Four things that must be true before you store a meaning.

YOU NEED

Recordings and Meaning Cards from Tool 1, a collaborator, 6–8 people from the same audience for the survey

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Glossary entries with literal and implied meanings, checked by other people, for Tool 3

NEXT PAGE **Part A • Thick translation →**

Thick translation

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

AS SAID	फ़ॉर्म तो भर दिया, अब ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी। Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi.
LITERAL	"I've filled the form, now it's the wish of the one above."
IN CONTEXT	She has done her part. The outcome is decided somewhere she can't see or reach.
ALTERNATIVES	"It's in God's hands." • "It's up to the officials now." • "Nothing more I can do."
IMPLIED	Loss of control, and not knowing who decides. Resigned, with a little humour.
SIGNALS	A short laugh before "marzi". Voice drops.
REVIEWED BY	Local language collaborator (Hindi, Bhojpuri). Added the "officials" reading.

LITERAL VS IMPLIED • THE USEFUL PART

Literally it's about **God**. What she meant is **an unknown official** deciding her fate.

TAKE TO PART B

Is "out of my hands, and I don't know who decides" what other students hear too?

Illustrative example.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Transcribe the moment in the original language and script.

2

Write the literal meaning, word for word.

3

Add context, alternatives, and the implied meaning.

4

Note small signals: exclamations, laughs, tone.

5

A local collaborator reviews it. Then go to Part B.

FROM MEANING CARD NO.

LANGUAGE(S) SPOKEN

REGION

AS SAID	[in their language and script, exactly as said]
LITERAL	[word for word]
IN CONTEXT	[what was happening when it was said]
ALTERNATIVES	[other ways it could be read]
IMPLIED	[what they really meant, with tone and feeling]
SIGNALS	[arre, haaye, a laugh, a tone]
REVIEWED BY	[who checked it]

LITERAL VS IMPLIED

Literally it means [God's wish]_____, but they meant [an unknown official decides]_____.

QUESTION TO TEST IN PART B • DO OTHER PEOPLE HEAR THE SAME THING?

NEXT

Part B • Reverse thick translation →

Reverse thick translation

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

8 first-generation students from the same colleges, **not** Meera. One survey sheet each (p.3.12), read aloud when needed. Directions 1 and 2 with everyone; direction 3 with the regional speakers.

1 Their language → meaning

SHOWN • ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी

ASKED • What does it literally say?
What would someone mean by it?
How would they sound?

"It's out of my hands now" **5**

"The officials will decide" **2**

Only the literal: "God's wish" **1**

Most hear the implied meaning.
Two point at officials, not God.

2 English → their language

SHOWN • "Your application is under review."

ASKED • What does this mean to you? Say it the way you'd say it to a friend.

"Abhi check ho raha hai" **3**

"Pending mein hai" **4**

"Upar gaya hai" (it's gone up) **1**

"Under review" becomes "gone up": the same unseen authority again.

3 Standard → regional

SHOWN • [Regional version from your collaborator]

ASKED • Does this mean the same to you? Does it sound the same?

[Same meaning] **[n]**

[Different meaning or tone] **[n]**

[What changed in the region: a word, the tone, the respect level]

SMALL SIGNALS CAPTURED ACROSS ALL SURVEYS

"arre" × 3 · frustration "haaye" × 1 · resignation laughed × 2 · before the phrase
tone · mostly resigned, 2 joking

SUPPORT CHECK • ALL FOUR NEEDED

- ✓ **Source language**
Hindi-English mix, recorded as said
- ✓ **Rendering**
Conceptual gloss

- ✓ **Who interpreted**
Local collaborator
- ✓ **More than one source?**
Yes: 8 people read it back

SUPPORTED

Store it. Add
"officials" as an
alternative.

GLOSSARY ENTRY → EXPRESSION LIBRARY

ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी · **Literal:** the wish of the one above · **Implied:** it's out of my hands, and I don't know who decides ·
Signals: resigned, a short laugh · **Read back by:** 8 people, 7 agree

Illustrative example. Counts are invented to show the method; [brackets] are for your own data.

How to use it

Next page • Survey sheet →

1

Pick 6–8 people from the same audience, not the original speaker.

2

Run directions 1 and 2 with everyone; 3 with regional speakers.

3

Record exactly what they say, plus tone and small signals.

4

Tally: implied, literal only, or something else.

5

Run the support check. Store it, or go back to Part A.

Survey sheet • one per person

PRINT + READ ALOUD

LANGUAGES SPOKEN AT HOME

DISTRICT / REGION

CODE (NO NAMES)

Age ☐ 18–24 ☐ 25–40 ☐ 40+ ☐ I agree to take part, and to be recorded

1 Their language → meaning

SHOW THE PHRASE IN THEIR LANGUAGE

[ऊपर वाले की मर्जी]

What does it say, word for word?

If someone said this to you, what would they mean?

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

2 English → their language

SHOW THE ENGLISH TEXT

[Your application is under review.]

What does this mean to you?

Say it the way you'd say it to a friend.

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

3 Standard → regional (only if relevant)

SHOW THE REGIONAL VERSION

[from your language collaborator]

Does it mean the same here?

Does it sound the same? What changes?

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

Small signals • write the word exactly

[arre, haaye, accha, a laugh, a sigh]

Researcher note • who else was present, anything odd

Tally + support check

BLANK TEMPLATE

DIRECTION 1 • THEIR LANGUAGE → MEANING	DIRECTION 2 • ENGLISH → THEIR LANGUAGE	DIRECTION 3 • STANDARD → REGIONAL
Read the implied meaning	Read the implied meaning	Read the implied meaning
Only the literal meaning	Only the literal meaning	Only the literal meaning
Something else · write it	Something else · write it	Something else · write it
What shifted?	What shifted?	What shifted?

Small signals across all sheets

["arre" × 3 · frustration; laughed × 2]

SUPPORT CHECK • TICK ALL FOUR, OR LOOP BACK

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Source language
The actual language and code-switching, not "English". | ☐ Who interpreted
None · coordinator · independent interpreter · professional. |
| ☐ Rendering
Verbatim quote · conceptual gloss · paraphrase only. | ☐ More than one source?
Did other people read it the same way, or does it rest on one person? |
- ☐ **Supported → store it**
 ☐ **Split → store with alternatives**
 ☐ **Not yet → back to Part A**

GLOSSARY ENTRY → EXPRESSION LIBRARY (TOOL 4)

PHRASE	[ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी]
LITERAL	[the wish of the one above]
IMPLIED	[it's out of my hands; I don't know who decides]
THE DIFFERENCE	[God → an unknown official]
SIGNALS	[resigned, a short laugh]
READ BACK BY	[8 people · 7 agree]

NEXT **Tool 3 • Test →**

Test

Does our wording work for this audience?

⌚ 45 MIN + TESTING

TEAM, THEN WITH PEOPLE

EFFORT ●●●

DESK, THEN FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Whether new wording is understood, can be used through a helper, and reads as trustworthy.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The wording passed all three lenses with the named audience, or went back for a rewrite.

WHAT IS IT?

Turn a supported meaning into a design hypothesis and a candidate wording. Check it against three lenses. Then test it with real people, in a different context from where you heard it. If it fails, rewrite, or take new questions back to Tool 1.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Hypothesis	"If we say ____, then ____ will happen."
Lens N • New	Works for someone who has never filled this exact form?
Lens P • Proxy	Still works read aloud by a CSC operator or a family member?
Lens T • Trust	Reads as official to someone primed to suspect a scam?
This audience	A named segment, never a generic user.

YOU NEED

A supported glossary entry from Tool 2, the screen you want to change

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Tested wording, ready for the Design Language Library

NEXT PAGE

Example • Rewriting "Pending" →

Candidate wording + three lenses

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

HYPOTHESIS

If the status names **who** is holding the application and **for how long**, students will stop reading “pending” as fate.

NOW

Status: Pending



CANDIDATE

Your college is checking your documents • day 3 of 15

आपका कॉलेज आपके दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है • दिन 3 / 15

THREE LENSES • THIS AUDIENCE: FIRST-GENERATION STUDENTS APPLYING ON A PHONE

N	New	Never filled this form. Knows WhatsApp and UPI, not portal words.	✓	Understood “college is checking”.
P	Proxy	Read aloud by her father over the phone.	✓	Father repeated it correctly.
T	Trust	Suspicious of anything that looks like a scam.	✗	“Call your college” link looked like a scam. Removed.

TESTED IN A DIFFERENT CONTEXT

Hostel common room, 6 students, and 2 fathers by phone. Comprehension and use.

RESULT

Round 2 passed all three lenses. Store in the Design Language Library.

Illustrative example. Check any translated UI copy with a native speaker before testing.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Write the hypothesis in one sentence.

2

Write candidate wording, in each language.

3

Check it against lenses N, P and T.

4

Test with the named audience, somewhere new.

5

Fails? Rewrite. New questions? Back to Tool 1.

Candidate wording + three lenses

BLANK TEMPLATE

HYPOTHESIS

If we say _____, then _____ will happen.

NOW • THE CURRENT WORDING

[Status: Pending]



CANDIDATE • EVERY LANGUAGE

*[Your college is checking your documents · day 3 of 15
/ आपका कॉलेज दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है]*

THIS AUDIENCE *[first-gen students]* using *[a shared phone]*, with *[a father]* reading it to them

N**New**

Works for someone who never filled this exact form?

✓ ✕

P**Proxy**

Works read aloud by a CSC operator or a family member?

✓ ✕

T**Trust**

Official, not scam-like? (no urgency, unofficial channel, fee)

✓ ✕

TESTED WHERE, WITH WHOM

[hostel common room, 6 students; 2 fathers by phone]

RESULT • STORE, REWRITE, OR NEW QUESTIONS

[T failed in round 1; rewrote; passed round 2 → store]

NEXT **Tool 4 • Library →**

Library

How do we keep what we learned, so the next team can use it?

🕒 20 MIN PER ENTRY WHOLE TEAM EFFORT ●○○ DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

A growing record of how people really speak, and which interface words have been tested with whom.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every supported phrase and every tested wording has an entry, with its evidence and its limits.

WHAT IS IT?

Two libraries. The Expression Library keeps supported meanings, de-identified. The Design Language Library keeps interface wording that passed testing. Together they are the start of a language system: like a design system, but for words.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Expression Library	How people say things, with literal and implied meanings.
---------------------------	---

Design Language Library	Tested interface wording, per language and audience.
--------------------------------	--

De-identified	No names, no details that point to one person.
----------------------	--

Don't use for	Where this wording or reading does not hold.
----------------------	--

YOU NEED

Supported entries from Tool 2 and tested wording from Tool 3

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Library entries your whole team, and the next project, can reuse

NEXT PAGE **Example · Two entries →**

Two linked entries

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN

EXPRESSION LIBRARY · EX-014		DESIGN LANGUAGE LIBRARY · DL-031	
EXPRESSION	ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी · upar wale ki marzi	MOMENT	Application status, after submitting
LANGUAGE	Hindi, used inside Hinglish speech	REPLACES	Status: Pending
LITERAL	The wish of the one above	ENGLISH	Your college is checking your documents · day 3 of 15
IMPLIED	Out of my hands; I don't know who decides	HINDI	आपका कॉलेज आपके दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है · दिन 3 / 15
HEARD WHEN	Waiting on an institution after submitting	TESTED WITH	First-gen students on phones; fathers by phone
EVIDENCE	3 participants · collaborator + second reader · supported	LENSES	N ✓ · P ✓ · T ✓ (round 2)
DON'T USE FOR	Religious meaning in every context. Ask first.	LINKED TO	EX-014 · tone: calm, specific, no urgency

Grows into a language system. Once there are enough tested entries, group them by moment (errors, waiting, success) and by voice (how formal, how warm), just like components in a design system.

Illustrative example.

How to use it

Next page · Blank entries →

1

Supported meaning? Write an Expression entry.

2

Remove names and identifying details.

3

Tested wording? Write a Design Language entry.

4

Link the two entries.

5

Say where each one does not hold.

Library entries

BLANK TEMPLATE

Print, cut out and file. Or copy the fields into a shared spreadsheet.

EXPRESSION LIBRARY • NO. ____	DESIGN LANGUAGE • NO. ____
EXPRESSION	MOMENT
LANGUAGE	REPLACES
LITERAL	ENGLISH
IMPLIED	LANGUAGE 2
HEARD WHEN	TESTED WITH
EVIDENCE	LENSES N·P·T
DON'T USE FOR	LINKED TO

EXPRESSION LIBRARY • NO. ____	DESIGN LANGUAGE • NO. ____
EXPRESSION	MOMENT
LANGUAGE	REPLACES
LITERAL	ENGLISH
IMPLIED	LANGUAGE 2
HEARD WHEN	TESTED WITH
EVIDENCE	LENSES N·P·T
DON'T USE FOR	LINKED TO

NEXT **Tool 5 • The Kahavat Relay →**

The Kahavat Relay

When words won't reach a meaning, can a drawing?

🕒 10 MIN PER PERSON 3-5 PEOPLE, ONE AFTER ANOTHER EFFORT ●○○ FIELD OR WORKSHOP

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

How a meaning travels from person to person: what survives, what shifts, and what gets added.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The chain has at least three rounds, and you have compared the first line with the last.

WHAT IS IT?

Give the first person a kahavat (a spoken idiom). They draw what it means to them, as a moment from their own life, and write one line in their own language. The next person sees **only the drawing**. They say what is happening, write their own line, and draw their version. Keep passing it on.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Kahavat	A spoken idiom, like “ek anaar, sau beemar”.
Drawn metaphor	Their picture of the idiom, as a moment from their life.
Own-language line	One sentence, in any language or script they choose.
Chain	Each drawing becomes the prompt for the next person.

→ COMPONENT 2

Each drawing is a participant-made image. Read it in Tool 2 • Read, tagged Reported.

→ COMPONENT 3 • TOOL 2

Each own-language line gets a thick translation.

YOU NEED

Idiom cards (p.3.23), relay sheets (p.3.22), pens, consent to share drawings

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Drawings for Component 2, own-language lines for Tool 2, and new questions for Tool 1

NEXT PAGE **Example • One anaar, three people →**

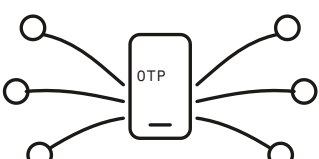
One anaar, three people

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN

IDIOM CARD एक अनार, सौ बीमार Ek anaar, sau beemar · one pomegranate, a hundred sick

ROUND 1 · P1 (MEERA)

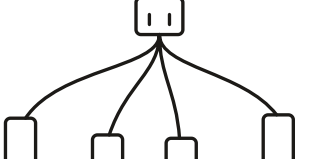
Sees the idiom card



एक ही फ़ोन है घर में, सबका OTP उसी पर आता है।
There's only one phone at home. Everyone's OTP comes to it.

ROUND 2 · P2

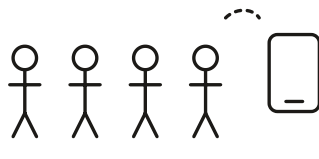
Sees only drawing 1



सब एक ही चीज़ के पीछे लगे हैं।
Everyone is after the same one thing.

ROUND 3 · P3

Sees only drawing 2



लाइन में लगे, बारी आएगी तब।
Stand in line, your turn will come.

SURVIVED

One resource, too many people.

SHIFTED

From who owns the phone → who waits for it.

ADDED

Turn-taking and time.

DESIGN QUESTION

Does the product assume one person, one phone? What happens to OTP timing when it's shared?

Illustrative example. Lines are shown in Hindi; participants write in whatever language and script they choose.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

First person gets an idiom card.
Ask: when has this happened to you?

2

They draw it as their own moment, and write one line.

3

Next person sees only the drawing.
What is happening?

4

They write a line and draw their own version.
Repeat.

5

Compare first and last: survived, shifted, added.

Relay sheet

BLANK TEMPLATE

IDIOM CARD _____ TOPIC _____

Fold the sheet so the next person sees only the last drawing. Never show them the idiom or the earlier lines.

ROUND 1CODE ____

Sees the idiom card

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 2CODE ____

Sees only drawing 1

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 3CODE ____

Sees only drawing 2

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

SURVIVED

SHIFTED

from [who owns it] to

[who waits]

ADDED

DESIGN QUESTION

Does the product

assume

[one person, one phone]?

Drawings → Component 2 · Tool 2 (tag Reported) Lines → Tool 2 · Translate

NEXT PAGE **Idiom cards →**

Idiom cards

PRINT + CUT

Six Hindi examples, three blanks. **Better: collect idioms from the participants' own language** in Before you start, and check each meaning with your language collaborator. Don't explain the meaning to the first person unless they ask.

KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 एक अनार, सौ बीमार <i>Ek anaar, sau beemar</i> LITERALLY • One pomegranate, a hundred sick USUALLY MEANS • One thing, far too many people who need it. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 ऊँट के मुँह में ज़ीरा <i>Oont ke munh mein jeera</i> LITERALLY • A cumin seed in a camel's mouth USUALLY MEANS • Far too little for what's needed. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 नाच न जाने, आँगन टेढ़ा <i>Naach na jaane, aangan tedha</i> LITERALLY • Can't dance, blames the crooked courtyard USUALLY MEANS • Blaming the surroundings for your own trouble. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 दूर के ढोल सुहावने <i>Door ke dhol suhaavne</i> LITERALLY • Distant drums sound sweet USUALLY MEANS • Things look better from far away. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 आसमान से गिरा, खजूर में अटका <i>Aasmaan se gira, khajoor mein atka</i> LITERALLY • Fell from the sky, stuck in a date palm USUALLY MEANS • Out of one trouble, straight into another. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 जितनी चादर, उतने पैर पसारो <i>Jitni chaadar, utne pair pasaaro</i> LITERALLY • Stretch your legs only as far as the sheet USUALLY MEANS • Live within what you have. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?

Is it working?

GOOD SIGNS

- ✓ A participant corrected your Meaning Card, and the correction changed your reading.
- ✓ The literal and implied meanings in your glossary are clearly different.
- ✓ A relay chain drifted, and the drift told you something the first person never said.
- ✓ Your tested wording failed a lens at least once before it passed.

WARNING SIGNS, AND WHAT TO DO

- ✗ Every phrase is written only in English.
Go back to the recording. Keep the original language and script.
- ✗ Nobody but you interpreted anything.
It is single-source. Find a language collaborator before you store it.
- ✗ “This audience” means “users”.
Name the segment: who, what device, who reads it to them.
- ✗ The relay's next person knew the idiom.
The chain is broken. Fold the sheet; show only the last drawing.

→ HANDS OFF TO

1 • Existing Products

Which screens use words people read differently?

→ HANDS OFF TO

2 • Visual Culture

Relay drawings as participant-made images.

→ HANDS OFF TO

4 • Material Reality

Who reads the screen aloud, and on whose phone?

AFTER COMPONENT 3

R · 3B

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 3-4 • CLAIM + REDACTION • FILL RIGHT AFTER 3.24 IS IT WORKING?

COMPONENT 3 • READING LANGUAGE

What did the process actually give me?
Not what I set out to find.

1 THE STANZA

Write one paragraph, not a list, about what you actually learned. Not what you set out to find. What the process gave you that you did not already have when you started.

[illegible]

2 REDACTION

Read your stanza back slowly.
Underline anything that might
come from your own familiarity,
frustration or background rather
than the evidence. What is left
un-underlined is the part you can
stand behind.

What's left that I can stand behind:

3 STILL UNKNOWN

Name one specific thing you went looking for and couldn't confirm. Not "there's a lot more to understand". The actual gap you hit.

I went looking for _____

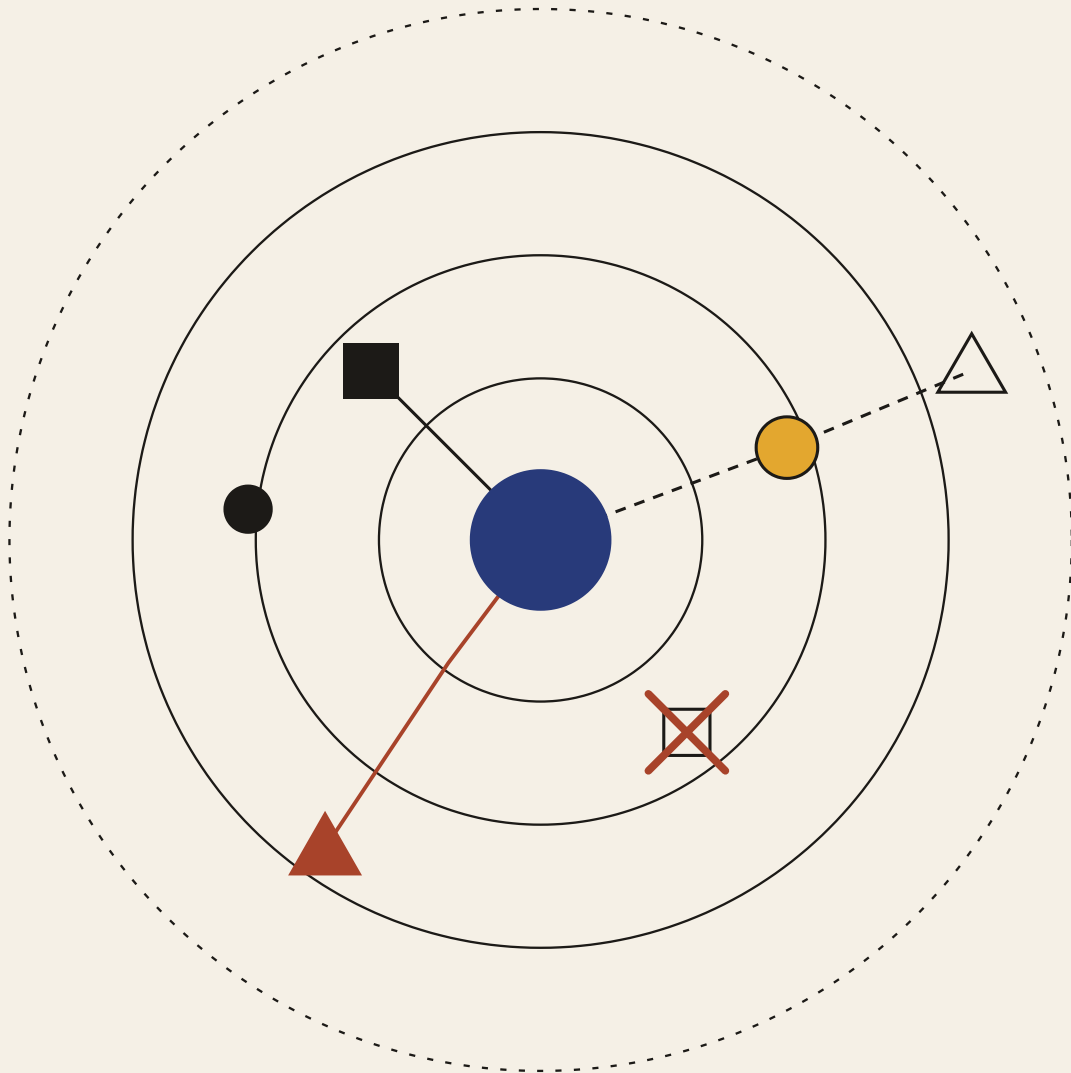
and couldn't confirm it because _____

Only using this component? Go to the Look back pages now (R-E1-E3, in Closing).

Using more? Clip this page to Before Component 3 (R-3A). Component 4 starts next.

Material Reality

Practical tools to see what people actually have, what it costs them, and who they lean on — before you design for them.



4 TOOLS

1 GUIDELINE

1 MAP

SCOLARSHIP PORTAL

What is material reality?

Everything around a screen that a person needs to get something done.
The phone, the data, the papers, the places, the people who help.
Products quietly assume all of it is there.

A "SIMPLE" UPLOAD ACTUALLY NEEDED

a charged phone

steady Wi-Fi

a scanner

knowing what a PDF is

the income certificate

₹50

her father's phone

WHAT TO LOOK FOR • NINE LAYERS



Devices

Whose phone, how old, how much space



Connection

Data, Wi-Fi, signal, recharges



Power

Battery, charging, power cuts



Places

Cybercafé, office, bank, home



Papers

Certificates, IDs, printouts



Money

What each step costs, and what it pushes aside



People

Who helps, who holds the phone, who knows how



Know-how

Knowing what an OTP or PDF is, in which language



Time & privacy

A quiet hour, a private corner

LOOK PAST

Do they have it?

TO

Can they really use it?

AND

Who and what do they lean on?

I want to...

Find what you need, go to that tool. Every tool works on its own. Used in order, they build one picture.

...see what my user's world actually holds

TOOL 1 · BUILD

p.4.06

...find where access breaks

TOOL 1 · BUILD

p.4.09

...see who people depend on to get it done

TOOL 2 · BREAK

p.4.11

...understand why people drop off

TOOL 2 · BREAK

p.4.14

...know what gets compromised in their lives

TOOL 3 · WEIGH

p.4.16

...turn findings into a clear problem

TOOL 4 · SAY

p.4.19

...OR RUN THEM ALL, IN ORDER

Visual Toolkit
photos + lenses



1 Build



2 Break



3 Weigh



4 Say

QUICK · ABOUT AN HOUR

**Tool 1 → Tool 2 → a three-line
brief**

DEEP · A FIELD VISIT

All four, with participants

BEFORE COMPONENT 4

R·4A

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEPS 1-2 · POSITION + PREDICTION · FILL BEFORE 4.04 MAP THE JOURNEY

COMPONENT 4 · READING MATERIAL REALITY

Before I begin,
I want to make my starting position visible.

1 POSITION

Your device. Your language at home. Your city.

Device _____

Language at home _____

City _____

Have you used this product, avoided it, or never needed it?

☐

Used it

☐

Avoided it

☐

Never needed it

Because _____

What else might shape how you see this person or product?

2 PREDICTION

FOR THIS COMPONENT, PREDICT

what your person will be missing, and what they use instead.

What do you expect to find?

Why do you expect to find that?

What do you think it could mean? What do you already know about this context that is making you predict this?

Keep this page visible while you work. Do not change the prediction until the component is complete.

WHEN THE COMPONENT IS DONE
AFTER COMPONENT 4 · R·4B

First, map the journey.

Tool 1 asks what a person uses at each step. You can only answer that once you know the steps. So write them down first.

ALREADY HAVE ONE?

Use your journey map or service blueprint. Need a refresher?

[Journey mapping 101 · NN/g](#)

[Service blueprints · NN/g](#)

Experience Map & Blueprint · Nesta DIY Toolkit

NEW TO THIS?

Use the Journey Strip below. For each step, write **where** they are and **what or who** they use. Nothing else.

Journey Strip · Meera

EXAMPLE

STEP	1 Sees the notice	2 Opens the portal	3 Makes the PDF	4 Gets the certificate	5 Enters the OTP	6 Uploads
WHERE	Hostel	Hostel room	Cybercafé	Home village	Hostel	Hostel
USES · WHO HELPS	Class WhatsApp, her phone	Phone, hostel Wi-Fi	₹50, the owner	Father, Tehsildar office	Father's phone	Data pack

Every item in the bottom row becomes something you place on the Loop in Tool 1.

Journey Strip · your person

BLANK

STEP	1	2	3	4	5	6
WHERE						
USES · WHO HELPS						

From the Visual Toolkit, bring these.

In the Visual Toolkit, participants photograph and film their surroundings and tag each picture with a lens. Those tagged pictures, and the inferences you drew from them, are what Tool 1 builds on.

1

Collect the photos, videos and lens tags.

2

Sort each one: person ●, thing ■ or place ▲.

3

Note how easy it is to reach: in hand, where they live, a trip away, or through someone.

4

Print them small. Bring them to the Loop with your Journey Strip.

FILLED EXAMPLE · MEERA'S PHOTOS, SORTED

P1  Wi-Fi router in the hostel corridor LENS: SHARED ■ WHERE SHE LIVES	P2  Cybercafé signboard near the bus stand LENS: WORKAROUND ▲ A TRIP AWAY	P3  Father's phone on the shelf at home (sent by family) LENS: SHARED ■ THROUGH SOMEONE
P4  Her phone at 12% battery, data almost used up LENS: ACCESS ■ IN HAND	P5  Video: queue outside the Tehsildar office LENS: MISSING ▲ THROUGH SOMEONE	P6  Senior's room — "he knows everything" LENS: WORKAROUND ● A TRIP AWAY

Lens names above are placeholders. Use the lenses from your Visual Toolkit.

ALSO BRING YOUR INFERENCES

Turn each one into a question for the Ladder. "The router is shared by 40 rooms" becomes: **does Wi-Fi keep working when she needs it?**

NO VISUAL TOOLKIT?

Tool 1 still works. Ask the person to walk you through the task and sketch what they point to.

Build

What does the task need, and where does it stop working?

⌚ 45 MIN 👤 SOLO OR WITH PARTICIPANT EFFORT ●●○ 📍 DESK OR FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Everything the task depends on, how easy each thing is to reach, and where each one stops working.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every step of the journey has something on the map, and every key item is checked on the ladder.

WHAT IS IT?

Two sheets. On the **Loop**, you place everything the task needs around the person. The easier something is to get to, the closer it sits. On the **Ladder**, you take the most important items and ask seven simple questions about each, to find where it fails.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE



Loop

A map of rings around the person. Inner rings are easier to reach.



Token

A sticker for a person ●, a thing ■ or a place ▲.



Line

One small action, like “borrows” or “pays for”.



Ladder

Seven yes/no questions, from “Does it exist?” to “Are they allowed to use it?”

YOU NEED

Your Journey Strip (p.4.04) and Visual Toolkit photos (p.4.05)

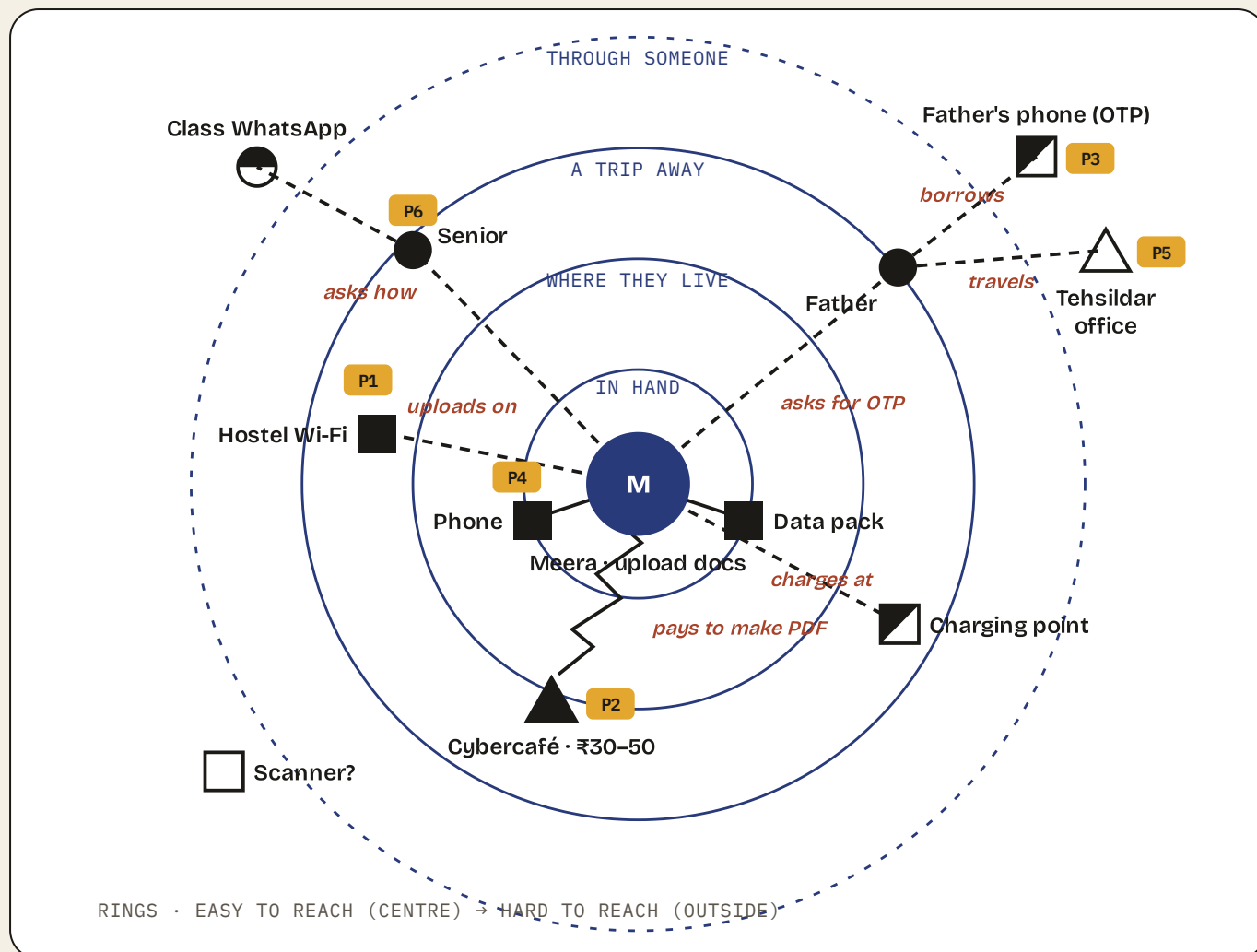
YOU'LL END UP WITH

A map of what the task needs, and where it breaks. Take the breaks to Tool 2.

NEXT PAGE **Example • The Loop →**

The Loop

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN



● ■ ▲ person · thing · place ■ photo - - - line = one action, *verb* on it
 solid / half / outline = seen / told / assumed

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Write the person and the task in the centre.

2

Add a token for each thing they used.

3

Put it on the ring for how easy it is to reach.

4

Draw a line for each action. Write the verb on it.

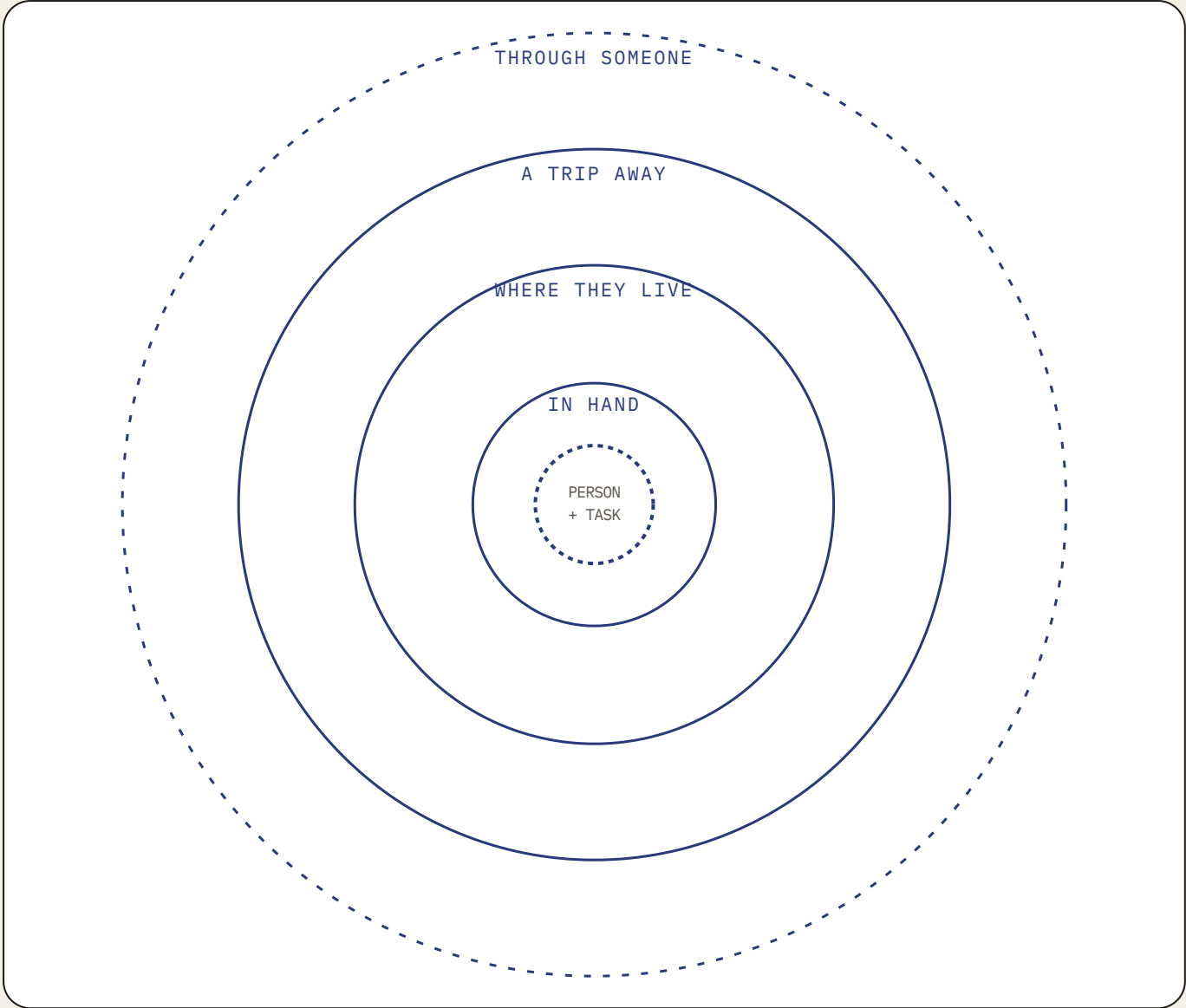
5

Stick the photos next to their tokens.

The Loop

BLANK TEMPLATE

PERSON _____ TASK _____ DATE _____



● Person

■ Thing

▲ Place

P1 Photo

Fill: seen · told · assumed Line = one small task. Owns — · borrows - - · pays for ^ . Write the verb on it.

Rings: easy to reach in the centre, hard to reach outside.

Next · Part B, the Ladder →

The Access Ladder

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

← DESIGNER CAN CHANGE MORE

DESIGNER CAN CHANGE LESS →

Key things →	PDF know-how	Father's phone (OTP)	Hostel Wi-Fi	Data pack	Income cert.	Own phone
Priority: designer influence	HIGH	HIGH	MED	MED	LOW	LOW
1 Exists Is it in their world?	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
2 Reachable Can they get to it?	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗ back home	✓
3 Affordable Can they pay once?	—	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
4 Sustainable Does it keep working?	—	✓	✗ drops	✗ runs out	—	✓
5 Theirs Owned or borrowed?	—	✗ his, not hers	shared	✓	—	✓
6 Usable Do they know how?	✗ what's a PDF?	✓	✓	✓	—	✓
7 Permitted Allowed to use it?	—	asks first	✓	✓	—	✓

☐ **Focus first.** Basic access, and the designer can change it.

☐ **Design for next.** Everyday use, and the designer can change it.

☐ **Push for change.** Basic access, but outside the product.

☐ **Keep an eye on.** Everyday use, outside the product.

Meera: her top-left corner is empty, so her team started bottom-left: PDF know-how, the OTP and Wi-Fi. All three are things the product can fix.

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Write the key things across the top.

2

Order them by your priority.

3

Go down each column. ✗ at the first "no".

4

Start with one shaded corner.

← HIGHER PRIORITY

LOWER PRIORITY →

Key things → write them in						
Priority: _____						
1 Exists Is it in their world?						
2 Reachable Can they get to it?						
3 Affordable Can they pay once?						
4 Sustainable Does it keep working?						
5 Theirs Owned or borrowed?						
6 Usable Do they know how?						
7 Permitted Allowed to use it?						

- Focus first.** Basic access, high priority.
- Push for change.** Basic access, lower priority.
- Design for next.** Everyday use, high priority.
- Keep an eye on.** Everyday use, lower priority.

Every × you marked can be taken into Tool 2 · Break.

p.4.11 →

Break

Who fills each gap, and what happens when they can't?

🕒 45–60 MIN

👤 WITH THE PERSON, OR A GROUP

EFFORT ●●○

📍 FIELD OR DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

Who the person turns to when something breaks, what gets lost on the way, and the few people everything depends on.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

Every break has someone who solved it (or ✕), and each of them has been taken out once.

WHAT IS IT?

It works like Chinese whispers. Take one thing that broke on the Ladder. Ask the person who they turned to, and who that person turned to. Write down what each one told them. Then imagine the most important helper isn't there one day, and see what happens.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Whisper

The chain of people the person asked, in order.

Facts

The few key pieces of information in the original notice or form, like “PDF only”.

Big player

Whoever finally solved the problem.

Cut

Imagining that the big player isn't available.

Play it live

Line up 4–6 people, one per role. The first reads the notice aloud and whispers it on. Compare the last line with the first, then ask one player to step out.

YOU NEED

The ✕s from your Ladder (p.4.09), and the person, or their chats and screenshots

YOU'LL END UP WITH

Your big players, and what fails without them

NEXT PAGE **Example • The Whisper →**

The Whisper

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

THE FACTS • FROM THE PORTAL'S NOTICE

Break: PDF know-how

- 1 PDF only
- 2 Max 200KB
- 3 Income certificate
- 4 Dated after 1 April

WHO SHE ASKED	WHAT THEY TOLD HER	1	2	3	4	ADDS
Roommate SHE TOLD US	"Make it a PDF, there's some app for that."	●	⊘	⊘	⊘	+1 hr
Class WhatsApp SCREENSHOT	"Scan all your docs, last date 30th."	⊘	⊘	●	⊘	+1 day
Senior SHE TOLD US	"Just go to the cybercafé, bhaiya knows."	⊘	⊘	⊘	⊘	+ hours
Cybercafé owner WE VISITED	Solves it for ₹30–50. Picks the file settings himself.					BIG PLAYER

REPEAT FOR EVERY × • THE BIG PLAYERS

PDF know-how → Cybercafé owner

OTP → Father

Wi-Fi drops → Her data pack

Data runs out → × Nobody

Certificate → Father

How to use it

Next page • Blank template →

1

Pick one × from your Ladder.

2

Copy the facts from the original notice.

3

Ask who they asked. Write what each one said.

4

Dot if a fact survived, cross if it was lost.

5

Whoever solved it is the big player.

The Whisper

BLANK TEMPLATE

BREAK FROM YOUR LADDER _____ STEP _____

THE FACTS • COPY THEM FROM THE ORIGINAL NOTICE, FORM OR MESSAGE

A fact is one piece of information the person needed to get it right.

1

2

3

4

WHO THEY ASKED	WHAT THEY WERE TOLD	1	2	3	4	ADDS
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						
☐ TOLD ☐ SHOWN ☐ SEEN						

BIG PLAYER

In the end, [the café owner] solved it, because they [knew the 200KB "setting"]

Only write what the person tells you, shows you (a chat, a screenshot) or what you see yourself. Fill the dot if the fact survived, cross it if it was lost.

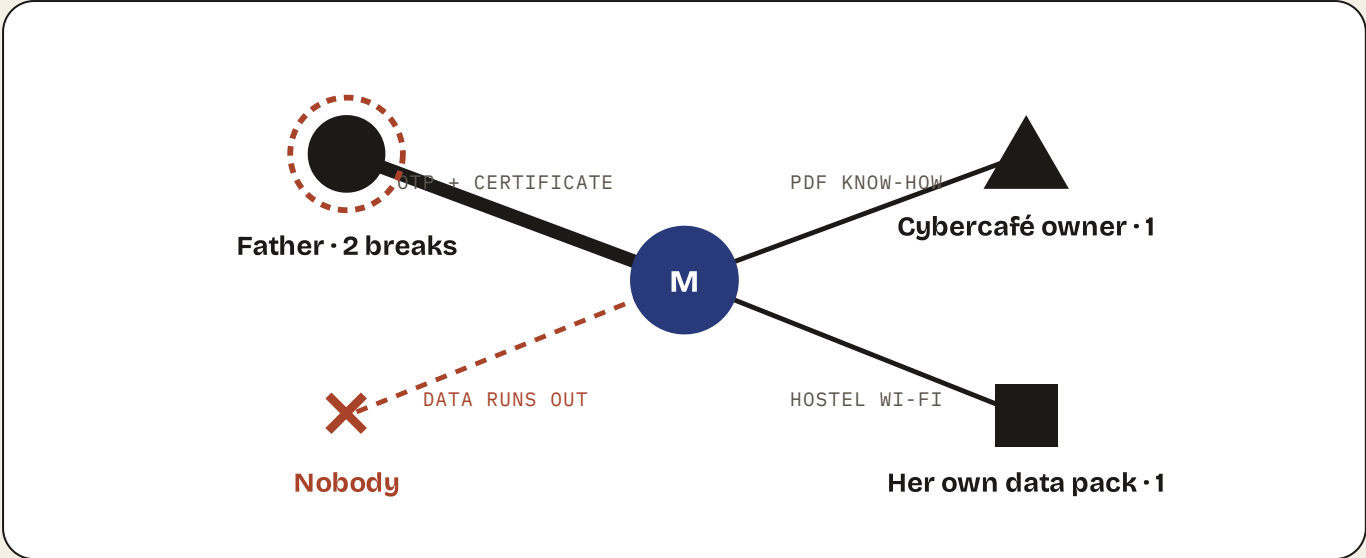
REPEAT FOR EVERY ×

BREAK	HOPS	BIG PLAYER

NEXT **Part B • Big players & the Cut →**

Big players & the Cut

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN



✗ Cut: Father isn't available		
DEPENDS ON HIM	FALLBACK	OUTCOME
OTP on his phone	Waits till evening, retries next day	✓ Done, a day late
Trip for the income certificate	No one else in the family can go	✗ Application incomplete

HOW COULD THE PRODUCT SHARE HIS LOAD?

Let Meera choose her own number for the OTP. Let the certificate be requested online, so no one has to travel.

How to use it

1

Put every big player around the person.

2

Draw one line per break they solve.

3

Imagine the busiest one isn't there.

4

Write the fallback, then ✓ or ✗.

5

Ask how the product could help them.

Next page • Blank template →

1 • Map. Write each big player in a circle. Draw one line per break that depends on them.

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

PERSON

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

BIG PLAYER

2 • Cut. Remove one big player at a time. Start with the one with the most lines.

× CUT:

DEPENDS ON THEM	FALLBACK	OUTCOME ✓ / ×

× CUT:

Without [the café owner], [the upload] stops working and [Meera] pays. The product could share their load by [accepting phone photos]

NEXT

Take the costs and Xs to Tool 3 • Weigh →

Weigh

What gets compromised first, and how many people live like this?

🕒 30 MIN + DESK TIME

👤 DONE WITH THE PERSON

EFFORT ●●●

📍 FIELD

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

What each cost from Tool 2 pushes aside in the person's life, and how common their situation is.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

The cards are sorted, the costs are placed, and each finding has a number with a source.

WHAT IS IT?

A card-sorting game you play **with** the person. They lay out everyday needs in the order they'd give them up when money or time is short. You place the costs you found on those cards. Later, at your desk, you back each finding with a statistic.

WORDS YOU'LL SEE

Need cards	Everyday needs: food, rent, bills, health, education, phone and data, travel...
Compromised first	What they would cut or delay first.
Count card	One finding. The story on the front, a number and its source on the back.

Take care: never ask about income. If family members disagree about the order, offer to sort in private.

YOU NEED

The need cards (p.4.18) and the costs you found in Tool 2

YOU'LL END UP WITH

What each cost pushes aside, and Count cards for Tool 4

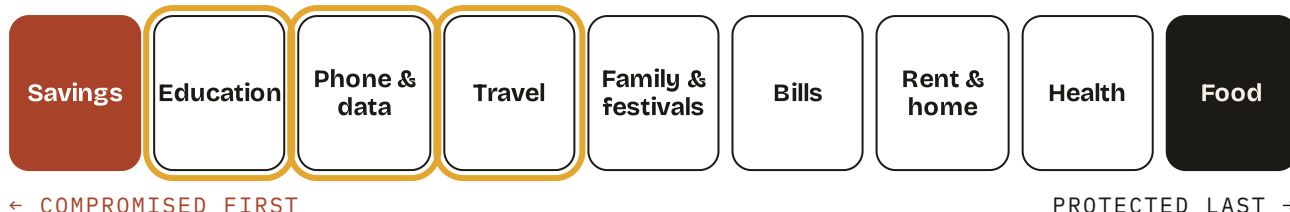
NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's family →**

What gets compromised first?

WORKED EXAMPLE • DON'T FILL IN

MEERA'S FAMILY

“When money or time is short, what gets compromised first?”



COSTS LAND ON Education (₹50 cybercafé), Phone & data (the lost upload), Travel (the family trip). All near the front of the line.

WHAT MOVES IT A medical bill pushes Health up and Education further down.

COUNT CARD • ONE FINDING

FRONT • THE STORY

“The OTP goes to my father's phone. He's in the field till evening.”

Tool 1: breaks at step 5 • Tool 2: Father is a big player

BACK • THE COUNT

HOW MANY

[Women in (state) with a phone of their own] — NFHS-5

IN THEIR MONEY

₹50 = []% of monthly spending per person — HCES 2022-23

EXPLAINS

Why OTPs so often go through a father's phone.

[Brackets]: fill with the real figure and its source. Never estimate.

How to use it

[Next page • Blank template →](#)
1

Hand over the need cards. They sort.

2

Ask what gets compromised first.

3

Place the costs on the cards.

4

Ask what changes the order.

5

Later, write a Count card.

What gets compromised first?

BLANK TEMPLATE

SORTING STRIP • LAY THE CARDS HERE

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

← COMPROMISED FIRST

PROTECTED LAST →

When money or time is short, [savings] goes first. The cost we found, [₹50 café trip], lands on [phone & data]

The order changes when [exams or a festival]

NEED CARDS • CUT OUT

Food	Rent & home	Bills	Health	Education	Phone & data	Travel	Family & festivals	Savings	Add yours
------	-------------	-------	--------	-----------	--------------	--------	--------------------	---------	-----------

Translate the cards into the local language, and add a picture to each for people who don't read.

COUNT CARD

FRONT • THE STORY

From Tool __ • step or big player: _____

BACK • THE COUNT

HOW MANY • SOURCE

IN THEIR MONEY

EXPLAINS

NEXT Take your findings to Tool 4 • Say →

Say

What kind of problem is this, really?

🕒 30 MIN 👤 SOLO OR TEAM EFFORT ●●○ 📍 DESK

WHAT IT SHOWS YOU

One clear statement of the problem, including who decided it and who pays for it.

YOU'RE DONE WHEN

A teammate who wasn't there can say what kind of problem it is, without seeing your maps.

WHAT IS IT?

A fill-in-the-blanks brief. You finish a few sentences about your biggest break, decide what kind of problem it is, and, if someone passed the cost on, say whose decision that was.

THREE KINDS OF PROBLEM

Oversight

Nobody thought of it.

Offload

Someone chose to pass the cost on to the person.

Constraint

The system doesn't allow otherwise, yet.

YOU NEED

What you found in Tools 1–3, and your Count cards

YOU'LL END UP WITH

A one-page brief to design from

NEXT PAGE **Example • The brief →**

The brief pad

WORKED EXAMPLE · DON'T FILL IN

The product assumed...	A computer, a scanner, steady internet, one sitting, an OTP on her own phone.
What existed was...	Her own phone, patchy Wi-Fi, prepaid data, no scanner, the certificate back home.
So she...	Asked around until she reached the cybercafé owner, and relied on her father twice.
It cost her...	3 days+ · ₹30–50 + data · a family trip. It ate into Education, the 2nd thing compromised.
This is...	OVERSIGHT no photo-to-PDF, no saving halfway. OFFLOAD proof of income on paper only.
↳ Whose decision was it?	The scheme's rules require a paper certificate from the Tehsildar.
↳ Who benefits · who pays?	The scheme avoids building an online check. Meera and her family pay in time, travel and money.
↳ Was it intentional?	The rule was. The cost to families probably wasn't thought through.
It is true for...	[How many — from the Count cards, with the source]
Prototype next...	Photo-to-PDF in the portal · save and come back · OTP to a number she chooses.

IN ONE LINE

The problem isn't the upload screen. It's three things the portal never helped her get, and one person she can't do without.

How to use it

Next page · Blank template →

1

Finish each sentence for your biggest break.

2

Pick the kind of problem.

3

If it's an offload, answer the ↳ questions.

4

Add the number. Write it in one line.

5

Test your idea back in Tool 2.

The brief pad

BLANK TEMPLATE

BREAK

PERSON

The product assumed...

[a scanner and a PDF]

What existed was...

[a phone camera and a café]

So they...

[paid ₹50 and lost a day]

It cost them...

[money, a day, and her father's time]

This is...

OVERSIGHT

OFFLOAD

CONSTRAINT

↳ **Whose decision was it?**

↳ **Who benefits · who pays?**

↳ **Was it intentional?**

YES

NO

NOT SURE

It is true for...

[[n] students in the survey · source]

Prototype next...

[photo-to-PDF inside the upload step]

Answer the three ↳ questions only if you picked Offload.

IN ONE LINE

Ask Your Participants

Ask about the task, never about what someone lacks.

TOOL 1 · BUILD

"Show me the last time you did this — from the very start."

TOOL 2 · BREAK

"Who did you ask? And who did they ask?"

TOOL 2 · BREAK

"Do you know anyone who tried and gave up?"

TOOL 3 · WEIGH

"When money is short, what gets compromised first?"

CONSENT · READ ALOUD

"There are no right answers. Skip anything, stop any time. We won't use your name, or anyone's who helped you."

CARE

Never ask income
Helpers by role, not name
Sensitive questions in private
Let them hold the cards
Go back and share what you found

AFTER COMPONENT 4

R·4B

CLAIM &
REFLECTION

STEPS 3-4 · CLAIM + REDACTION · FILL RIGHT AFTER 4.22 ASK YOUR
PARTICIPANTS

COMPONENT 4 · READING MATERIAL REALITY

What did the process actually give me?
Not what I set out to find.

1 THE STANZA

Write one paragraph, not a list, about what you actually learned. Not what you set out to find. What the process gave you that you did not already have when you started.

2 REDACTION

Read your stanza back slowly. **Underline** anything that might come from your own familiarity, frustration or background rather than the evidence. What is left un-underlined is the part you can stand behind.

What's left that I can stand behind:

3 STILL UNKNOWN

Name one specific thing you went looking for and couldn't confirm. Not "there's a lot more to understand". The actual gap you hit.

I went looking for _____

and couldn't confirm it because _____

Only using this component? Go to the Look back pages now (R·E1-E3, in Closing).

Using more? Clip this page to Before Component 4 (R·4A). Closing starts next.

LOOK BACK: SUMMARISE

R·E1

CLAIM & REFLECTION

STEP 5 · LOOK BACK 1 OF 3 · RETURN TO YOUR PREDICTIONS

Open your predictions.
Keep them in front of you.

☐ C1 · R·1A

☐ C2 · R·2A

☐ C3 · R·3A

☐ C4 · R·4A

1 SURPRISE

What surprised you? What did you almost scroll past or skip over that turned out to matter?

2 THE MUNDANE THAT MOVED THINGS

What seemed irrelevant or too obvious to note, but changed something when you looked closer?

3 COMPASS

Three lines. Finish each one.

Something I will always **refuse** to do in this kind of work:

Something I will always **make sure** I do:

Something I will go **much deeper** into next time:

Compare, don't rewrite. Leave your predictions as they were. The gap between them and this page is the finding.

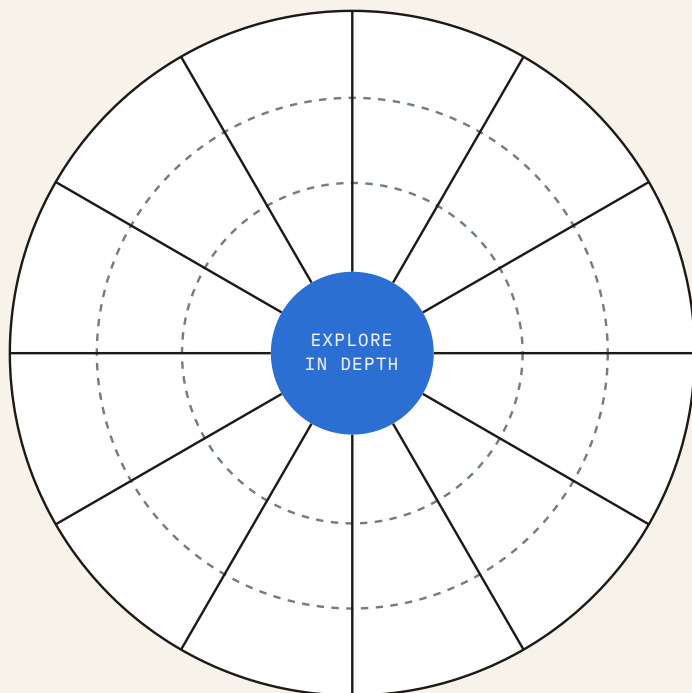
LOOK BACK: WHEEL

R · E2

CLAIM & REFLECTION

LOOK BACK 2 OF 3 · MAP WHAT YOU COULD ACTUALLY REACH

A dimension you didn't explore
is still part of the situation.



Outer ring · touched it Middle · looked into it
Centre · in depth

Write one dimension on each wedge. Shade each wedge as far in as you actually went. Leave blank, or mark with x, the ones you couldn't reach.

1 THE QUESTION

What's notably missing from your wheel?

Why do you think it stayed out of reach?

SUGGESTED WEDGES TO PICK FROM

Legal

Political

Economic

Ecological

Cultural

Caste & Class

Gender

Language

Labour

Infrastructure

Trust

Time

LOOK BACK: CONSEQUENCES

R·E3

CLAIM & REFLECTION

LOOK BACK 3 OF 3 • UNINTENDED CONSEQUENCES • PUSH THE METHOD FURTHER

What did this process prevent?
And what could it still produce?

1 IF YOU HAD SKIPPED IT

If you had skipped this whole process and gone straight to building, what would you likely have missed, assumed, or got wrong? What would that have cost someone?

2 LOOK AGAIN

Now look at the decisions and the process you did follow. Name one way your approach, your choices or your framing could still land badly on someone you haven't accounted for.

Who _____

How it could land _____

3 PLURIVERSE

What disappears when there is only one world?

If this product had to be built for one single, standard, universal user, what would your team have had to pretend didn't exist?

And if you were building for a completely different kind of world, what would you no longer have had to consider at all?



FINAL CHECK Can someone else read this and tell what you learned, what you could evidence, and what you still don't know?

It doesn't end here.

- 1** Test your idea: run it back through the Villain Story (1.07) or the Cut (4.14).
 - 2** Carry the brief into the next component.
 - 3** Re-map the same person in six months.
 - 4** Write your own tool card — and share it back.
-

FURTHER READING

Escobar — *Designs for the Pluriverse*

Sen — the capability approach

Max-Neef — *Human Scale Development*

Silverstone & Haddon — domestication of ICTs

Barber & Badre — culturability

Nesta — *DIY Toolkit*

**Make the complexity
visible without
making the
interaction complex.**

OUR FORM PRINCIPLE